

# The Four Marian Dogmas

What the Church Has Defined about Mary

A source-audited doctrinal reference

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# 1 Four Dogmas, One Economy

The Catholic Church counts four truths about the Blessed Virgin Mary among its dogmas: that she is truly Mother of God (*Theotokos*); that she is ever-virgin—before, in, and after the birth of her Son; that she was conceived immaculate, preserved from all stain of original sin from the first instant of her conception; and that, her earthly life completed, she was assumed body and soul into heavenly glory. This reference states, for each of the four, exactly what was defined, by whom, with what authority, and from what scriptural and traditional roots; what the definition does not assert; and how the Church presently teaches it.

A dogma, in the Church’s strict usage, is a truth contained in the word of God, written or handed down, which the Church proposes as divinely revealed—whether by a solemn judgment or by her ordinary and universal magisterium—and which therefore calls for the assent of divine and Catholic faith. The First Vatican Council fixed that criterion in its constitution *Dei Filius* (1870).<sup>1</sup> Not every true or authoritative statement about Mary is a dogma: the four treated here are the ones commonly so identified because each meets that strict standard. Their modes of proposal differ, and the differences matter.

## Governing thesis

The four Marian dogmas confess one work of God, not four privileges of Mary considered alone. Because the eternal Son truly became man from her, she is Mother of God; because her whole self was given to that motherhood, she is ever-virgin; because the Redeemer’s merits reached her first and most perfectly, she was preserved from original sin; because her body shared the Redeemer’s victory, she was assumed into glory. Each dogma was defined in a different mode—two in the ancient conciliar and traditional inheritance, two by solemn papal definition—and each leaves identified questions deliberately open. Everything defined is received: nothing in the four makes Mary a source of grace independent of Christ, the sole Redeemer and Mediator.

The two ancient dogmas were fixed in the Christological crisis of the fifth to seventh centuries: the divine motherhood at the Council of Ephesus (431) and in the councils that received it, the perpetual virginity through the Church’s universal tradition, confessed in creeds and councils and given an exact threefold formulation by the Lateran Council of 649. The two modern dogmas were defined *ex cathedra* by Pius IX in *Ineffabilis Deus* (1854) and Pius XII in *Munificentissimus Deus* (1950)—the two acts universally cited as exercises of the papal teaching authority that the First Vatican Council would define in 1870. Denial of a dogma is not mere disagreement with a theological school; both modern definitions attach a formal sanction to willful denial, quoted below with their texts.

Method, throughout: the exact defined text is quoted from an identified witness and set off typographically; the doctrinal history is traced to the definition, not read backwards from it; scriptural and patristic evidence is weighted honestly, with translation cares stated; and the boundary between dogma, authoritative teaching, and theological opinion is kept explicit, above all for the disputed cooperation titles treated in the final chapters. Work-wide bounds, terminology, and qualifications are gathered in the terminal appendix.

## The four definitions at a glance

The table states, for each dogma, the act that carries it, the operative Latin as the identified witness prints it, and the level of the act. The chapters and their notes control; the table condenses and cannot qualify them.

| Dogma                                  | Act and date                                                                                                                              | Operative words (Latin witness)                                                                                                                                                                                                         | Level and assent                              |
|----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Divine motherhood ( <i>Theotokos</i> ) | Council of Ephesus, 431: approval of Cyril’s second letter to Nestorius (DS 250–251); received at Chalcedon 451 and Constantinople II 553 | Greek original; the conciliar substance is that the Virgin is <i>Theotokos</i> because the Word “personally united” to himself the body born of her. Lateran 649, can. 3 gives the Latin equivalent: <i>Dei genitricem . . . Mariam</i> | Ecumenical council; divine and Catholic faith |

| Dogma                                          | Act and date                                                                                                                                           | Operative words (Latin witness)                                                                                                                                                                                      | Level and assent                                                                                   |
|------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Perpetual virginity<br>( <i>aeiparthenos</i> ) | Universal Tradition and ordinary universal magisterium; Constantinople II 553 (DS 427); exact formulation at the Lateran Synod of 649, can. 3 (DS 503) | “... <i>semperque Virginem et immaculatam Mariam ... absque semine concepisse ex Spiritu Sancto, et incorruptibiliter eum genuisse, indissolubili permanente et post partum eiusdem virginitate</i> ”                | Ancient dogma; conciliar and synodal formulation; divine and Catholic faith                        |
| Immaculate Conception                          | Pius IX, <i>Ineffabilis Deus</i> , 8 December 1854 (DS 2803), with formal sanction (DS 2804)                                                           | “ <i>declaramus, pronuntiamus et definimus doctrinam, quae tenet beatissimam Virginem Mariam in primo instanti suae conceptionis ... ab omni originalis culpae labe praeservatam immunem, esse a Deo revelatam</i> ” | Solemn papal definition <i>ex cathedra</i> ; divine and Catholic faith; sanction on willful denial |
| Assumption                                     | Pius XII, <i>Munificentissimus Deus</i> §44, 1 November 1950 (DS 3903), with sanction (§45; DS 3904)                                                   | “ <i>pronuntiamus, declaramus et definimus divinitus revelatum dogma esse: Immaculatam Deiparam semper Virginem Mariam, expleto terrestres vitae cursu, fuisse corpore et anima ad caelestem gloriam assumptam</i> ” | Solemn papal definition <i>ex cathedra</i> ; divine and Catholic faith; sanction on willful denial |

Two features of the table are doctrinally load-bearing. First, the operative words of the two ancient dogmas were not minted as definitions of a Marian privilege: they occur inside Christological canons, and the Marian clause is there because the council is stating who Christ is. Second, the two modern definitions are self-describing in a way the ancient ones are not—each names its own act (*definimus*), its own object, and its own sanction, and each therefore fixes the exact proposition to which faith is owed.<sup>2</sup>

## 2 The Scriptural Foundations

Four scriptural loci do most of the work in the Marian dogmas, and each of them is regularly asked to carry more than it can. This chapter treats them once, at their own linguistic and canonical scale, so that the chapters on the individual dogmas can cite rather than repeat them. The governing rule is the one the Church herself follows in these texts: Scripture is read within the rule of faith, and what Scripture supplies is the reality the later formula protects, not the formula itself.

### The greeting: *kecharitomene* (Lk 1:28)

Gabriel does not address Mary by her name. The Douay-Rheims renders the greeting: “Hail, full of grace, the Lord is with thee: blessed art thou among women.”<sup>3</sup> The word behind “full of grace,” transliterated *kecharitomene*, is a perfect passive participle of the verb *charitoo*, “to grace,” “to favor”—so that the greeting, in its grammar, says something like “you who have been and remain graced.” Three observations are exact, and a fourth is not.

Exact: the participle is passive, so the grace is received, never self-generated; it is perfect, so it names a state already established before the angel speaks, not a gift conferred by the greeting; and it stands where a name would stand, so the evangelist presents it as characterizing her. The Latin tradition renders it *gratia plena*, which is what the Douay-Rheims translates; many modern versions render “favored one” or “you who are highly favored,” and the difference is real: “full of grace” invites a reading in terms of a quantity of grace possessed, “favored one” in terms of divine regard shown. Both translate a participle that says less than the first and more than the second.

Not exact: the inference from the participle alone to the 1854 definition. Grammar establishes a prior and abiding gracing; it does not establish the instant at which the gracing began, and the first instant of conception is precisely what 1854 defines. *Ineffabilis Deus* does not argue otherwise. Its section on the Annunciation reports what the Fathers and ecclesiastical writers concluded when they “meditated on the fact that the most Blessed Virgin was, in the name and by order of God himself, proclaimed full of grace by the Angel Gabriel”—a patristic reading reported as such, inside a cumulative argument from liturgy, papal teaching, and tradition.<sup>4</sup> The Catechism follows the same order: it quotes the greeting, then the definition, and presents the second as the Church’s reading of what the first implies once the whole of Revelation is in view—not as a translation of the participle.

## The Woman and her seed (Gen 3:15)

God's word to the serpent after the fall is quoted in the Douay-Rheims: "I will put enmities between thee and the woman, and thy seed and her seed: she shall crush thy head, and thou shalt lie in wait for her heel."<sup>5</sup> Here the translation care is not optional, and this reference states it plainly. The Vulgate tradition that the Douay renders reads *ipsa conteret*, "*she* shall crush"; the Hebrew subject is masculine and refers to the seed, hence "he" or "it shall crush." The Douay-Rheims prints the divergence in its own annotation: "*Ipsa*, the woman; so divers of the fathers read this place, conformably to the Latin: others read it *ipsum*, viz., the seed. The sense is the same: for it is by her seed, Jesus Christ, that the woman crushes the serpent's head."<sup>6</sup>

The doctrinal argument does not depend on the pronoun. What the tradition and both modern constitutions actually take from the verse is the *enmity*—a hostility between the serpent and the woman, and between their seeds, that God himself establishes and that ends in victory. *Ineffabilis Deus* reads the verse this way: the Fathers "taught that by this divine prophecy the merciful Redeemer of mankind, Jesus Christ, the only begotten Son of God, was clearly foretold: that his most Blessed Mother, the Virgin Mary, was prophetically indicated; and, at the same time, the very enmity of both against the evil one was significantly expressed."<sup>7</sup> *Munificentissimus Deus* takes the same verse for the Assumption, adding the second Pauline term: the struggle foretold in the protoevangelium "would finally result in that most complete victory over the sin and death which are always mentioned together in the writings of the Apostle of the Gentiles" (§39, citing 1 Cor 15:54).<sup>8</sup> One verse, therefore, grounds two different dogmas by two different routes—preservation from sin in 1854, victory over death in 1950—and in both the route runs through the woman's association with her seed, never around him.

## The Woman clothed with the sun (Rev 12)

"And a great sign appeared in heaven: A woman clothed with the sun, and the moon under her feet, and on her head a crown of twelve stars."<sup>9</sup> The image is genuinely polyvalent, and honesty requires saying so before saying anything else. Within the book, the woman who bears the male child and is then persecuted in the wilderness carries Israel, from whom the Messiah comes, and the Church, persecuted after him; the Marian reading is a third sense that the tradition has read with the other two, not a replacement for them. Her crown of twelve stars fits Israel's tribes and the apostolic Church at least as naturally as it fits a Marian coronation.

*Munificentissimus Deus* is careful with this text in a way that deserves imitation. It does not cite Revelation 12 as a narrative proof of the Assumption. It reports that "the scholastic Doctors have recognized the Assumption of the Virgin Mother of God as something signified, not only in various figures of the Old Testament, but also in that woman clothed with the sun whom John the Apostle contemplated on the Island of Patmos" (§27)—a report of how theologians read a figure, inside a survey of the tradition's reasoning.<sup>10</sup> The same paragraph's neighbors report the theologians' use of Psalm 132 ("Arise, O Lord, into your resting place: you and the ark, which you have sanctified") and of the Canticle—also as the figures theologians employed, and also without conversion into proof.

## Cana and the Cross (Jn 2:1–11; 19:25–27)

The Fourth Gospel gives Mary two scenes and no name: she is "the mother of Jesus," and in both scenes her Son addresses her as "Woman." At Cana she states the need—"They have no wine"—and receives the reply, "Woman, what is that to me and to thee? my hour is not yet come"; she then tells the servants, "Whatsoever he shall say to you, do ye."<sup>11</sup> At the cross: "When Jesus therefore had seen his mother and the disciple standing whom he loved, he saith to his mother: Woman, behold thy son. After that, he saith to the disciple: Behold thy mother. And from that hour, the disciple took her to his own."<sup>12</sup>

Neither scene defines a dogma, and neither is treated here as though it did. What they supply is the shape within which the dogmas are read: a mother whose petition is answered on the Son's terms and whose last recorded word points away from herself to him; and a maternity that the dying Christ extends beyond nature to a disciple. The Church's authoritative teaching draws exactly that consequence and no more—the Catechism reads Mary's motherhood as extending "to all men whom indeed he came to save" (CCC 501), and *Lumen gentium* 58 sets her faithful standing at the cross inside her Son's saving work.<sup>13</sup>

## What Scripture does and does not settle

Directly attested: the virginal conception (Mt 1:18–25; Lk 1:26–35); that the one born of Mary is the Lord (Lk 1:43) and God’s own Son sent “made of a woman” (Gal 4:4; Jn 1:14); that she is greeted as already graced (Lk 1:28); that she consents (Lk 1:38) and stands at the cross (Jn 19:25). Not narrated anywhere: her conception by her parents, the manner of Christ’s birth, her later life, her death, her assumption. Three of the four dogmas therefore rest on a canonical horizon rather than a narrative text, and the Church says so in her own documents—most plainly in *MD* §38, which claims for the Fathers’ and theologians’ proofs only that they are “based upon the Sacred Writings as their ultimate foundation.”<sup>14</sup> A reference that pretended otherwise would be doing the dogmas no service; the Church’s own case is stronger than the proof-texts sometimes offered for it.

## 3 Mother of God: the Divine Motherhood

### The defined object and its authority

The dogma: Mary is truly Mother of God, because the Son she conceived and bore according to the flesh is the eternal Word of God in person. The controlling act is the Council of Ephesus (431), which did not issue a new creed but judged Cyril of Alexandria’s second letter to Nestorius to be the faith of Nicaea. The conciliar acts record that after the letters of Cyril to Nestorius were read, “the Holy Synod approved” them “as being orthodox and without fault,” in no point disagreeing with Scripture or with the faith of Nicaea.<sup>15</sup> The letter’s decisive sentence, in the same public-domain translation:

**Defined text — Cyril’s second letter to Nestorius, approved at Ephesus, 431 (DS 251)**

“This was the sentiment of the holy Fathers; therefore they ventured to call the Holy Virgin, the Mother of God, not as if the nature of the Word or his divinity had its beginning from the Holy Virgin, but because of her was born that holy body with a rational soul, to which the Word being personally united is said to be born according to the flesh.”<sup>16</sup>

The Council of Chalcedon (451) made the title part of its Definition of Faith—the Son is “born [into the world] of the Virgin Mary, the Mother of God according to his manhood”—and the Second Council of Constantinople (553) anathematized whoever calls her Mother of God only “in a false acceptance” or “in a relative sense.”<sup>17</sup> The dogma is thus conciliar, defined within Christology: what was at stake at Ephesus was not a privilege of Mary but the unity of Christ.

### Before the controversy: the second and third centuries

The title was neither invented at Ephesus nor smuggled in from devotion—but neither is it found, in its later form, in the earliest witnesses, and this reference does not project it backwards. What the early witnesses supply is the substance the word would later protect.

Ignatius of Antioch, writing to the Ephesians early in the second century, states the two births in one breath: “our God, Jesus Christ, was, according to the appointment of God, conceived in the womb by Mary, of the seed of David, but by the Holy Ghost.” A chapter later he calls “the virginity of Mary” and her offspring and the death of the Lord “three mysteries of renown, which were wrought in silence by God”; earlier in the same letter he had described the one Physician as “both of Mary and of God.”<sup>18</sup> That predication—one subject, “both of Mary and of God”—is the whole of the later argument in embryo.

Irenaeus, near the end of the second century, supplies the other element: Mary read against Eve inside a doctrine of recapitulation. In *Adversus haereses* III.22.4 he sets Eve’s disobedience while yet a virgin against “Mary the Virgin . . . found obedient,” so that as Eve “was made the cause of death, both to herself and to the entire human race; so also did Mary . . . by yielding obedience, become the cause of salvation, both to herself and the whole human race”; and he closes: “thus also it was that the knot of Eve’s disobedience was loosed by the obedience of Mary. For what the virgin Eve had bound fast through unbelief, this did the virgin Mary set free through faith.”<sup>19</sup> Irenaeus’s

Mariology is thus not a set of privileges but a structural role inside the reversal of Adam's fall: the same logic *Lumen gentium* 56 and both modern constitutions would later use.

Devotional address to Mary appears in the same centuries, but its earliest surviving instance is exactly the kind of evidence that must be dated before it is used. The prayer known as *Sub tuum praesidium* is preserved in a Greek papyrus (P. Ryl. III 470, Manchester) long dated to the third or fourth century—the dating on which the prayer's fame as the oldest Marian prayer rests—but recent palaeographic work has argued for a substantially later date, “the 6th/7th or even 8th/9th century,” which would make a Vienna transcription the oldest attestation.<sup>20</sup> This study therefore uses the prayer as evidence that direct invocation of the *Theotokos* existed in the Greek-speaking Church before the medieval liturgical books, and not as a dated third-century proof. The dogma does not need it, and the honesty is worth more than the early date.

## The controversy, 428–433

The dispute began not with a treatise but with a sermon. Nestorius became bishop of Constantinople in 428; the immediate occasion, as the nineteenth-century editor of the relevant NPNF volume reports, was a sermon by his chaplain Anastasius inveighing against the title *Theotokos*, which Nestorius then defended and developed.<sup>21</sup> The objection had a serious motive. If “God-bearer” meant that the Godhead took its origin from Mary, it was blasphemy; if it meant that a divine nature was born, it was incoherent. *Christotokos*, “Mother of Christ,” seemed to Nestorius the safe term.

Cyril's answer, in the second letter, was that the objection dissolves once the unity of Christ is held: the Word was not changed into flesh, nor joined to a separate man, but “personally united” himself to flesh animated by a rational soul. Both parties appealed to Rome early in 430. Celestine's Roman synod condemned Nestorius; at Rome the archdeacon Leo—the future Leo the Great—turned to John Cassian, whose Greek and Constantinopolitan connections fitted him for the task, and Cassian produced in haste the seven books *On the Incarnation of the Lord, Against Nestorius* before the council met.<sup>22</sup>

Cyril's third letter, sent in the name of the Alexandrian synod, is a harder document than the second, and its ending is the reason: appended to it are the twelve anathemas that Nestorius was required to subscribe. The first is the Marian one:

**Defined text — Cyril of Alexandria, first of the twelve anathemas appended to the third letter to Nestorius (430)**

“If anyone will not confess that the Emmanuel is very God, and that therefore the Holy Virgin is the Mother of God, inasmuch as in the flesh she bore the Word of God made flesh [as it is written, The Word was made flesh] let him be anathema.”<sup>23</sup>

The logic is worth marking: the anathema does not begin with Mary. It begins with “the Emmanuel is very God” and derives the title from it (“and *therefore* the Holy Virgin is the Mother of God”). Every subsequent Marian definition repeats that order.

The status of the twelve is a genuine historical complication, and this reference states it rather than smoothing it. Nestorius answered with twelve counter-anathemas, which the same volume prints alongside; the Antiochenes suspected Cyril's twelve of Apollinarian tendency; and the surviving extracts of the Ephesine acts break off just where the discussion of them should stand—Percival's own bracketed note reads: “It seems almost certain that something has dropped out here, most probably the whole discussion of Cyril's XII. Anathematisms.”<sup>24</sup> The council proceeded to sentence: “compelled thereto by the canons and by the letter . . . of our most holy father and fellow-servant Coelestine, the Roman bishop, we have come, with many tears, to this sorrowful sentence against him, namely, that our Lord Jesus Christ, whom he has blasphemed, decrees by the holy Synod that Nestorius be excluded from the episcopal dignity, and from all priestly communion.”<sup>25</sup>

## The Formula of Reunion (433): the settlement that held

The council did not end the schism; a negotiated confession did. In 433 Cyril accepted a formula drawn up by the Antiochenes and sent it back to John of Antioch in the letter beginning “Let the heavens rejoice”—the document later read aloud at Chalcedon and often called the Ephesine Creed. Its Marian sentence is the settled form of the dogma:

**Defined text — Formula of Reunion, quoted in Cyril’s letter to John of Antioch, 433 (read at Chalcedon, 451)**

“According to this understanding of this unmixed union, we confess the holy Virgin to be Mother of God; because God the Word was incarnate and became Man, and from this conception he united the temple taken from her with himself.”<sup>26</sup>

Two things follow. First, the dogma survived a real theological negotiation and was received by both parties to it—which is why Chalcedon could later have Cyril’s letters read and hear the bishops cry out, “We all so believe.” Second, the title’s justification in the settled text is strictly Christological: she is Mother of God *because* God the Word was incarnate, and what she supplies is the humanity—“the temple taken from her”—that he united to himself.

Reception in the Latin West is visible within a decade. Vincent of Lérins, writing about 434, insists that Mary “is to be confessed most truly and most blessedly—The mother of God ‘Theotocos,’” and then excludes the wrong reason for saying it: not as one may call a woman the mother of a priest or a bishop, because she bore someone who *afterwards became* such, but because in her womb the union of person was wrought.<sup>27</sup>

## Scripture, honestly weighted

Scripture never uses the word *Theotokos*; it supplies the reality the word protects. Elizabeth greets Mary as “the mother of my Lord” (Lk 1:43); Paul writes that “God sent his Son, made of a woman” (Gal 4:4); John, that “the Word was made flesh” (Jn 1:14).<sup>28</sup> The inference is short and ancient: if the one born of Mary is God the Son, then Mary is the mother of God the Son—mother of a person, not manufacturer of a nature. Motherhood terminates in the person born, and the person born of Mary is the eternal Word. Cyril’s third letter makes the same move from the same texts, and adds the reason the Word submitted to birth at all: that “he might bless the beginning of our existence.”<sup>29</sup>

## What the dogma does and does not assert

It asserts: the child of Mary is God the Son in person; his conception and birth from her are truly the conception and birth, according to the flesh, of the Word. It does not assert: that Mary is the origin of the divine nature; that she existed before God or is mother of the Trinity; that anything divine “began” in her. The common misunderstanding runs in both directions—Nestorius’s fear that the title deifies Mary, and the converse modern reading that “Mother of God” claims too much for her. Both dissolve on the same distinction: mothers bear persons, not natures. The Catechism gives the current catechetical form: the one Mary conceived “was none other than the Father’s eternal Son” and the Church confesses her as truly Mother of God (CCC 495, citing DS 251; cf. CCC 484–487).<sup>30</sup> *Lumen gentium* opens its Marian chapter from the same point: Mary is honored “as being truly the Mother of God and of the redeemer” (LG 53, quoted at CCC 963).<sup>31</sup> The divine motherhood is the ground of every other Marian dogma: the remaining three state what God’s grace made of the woman whose Son is God.

## Development milestones

| Date     | Milestone                                                                                                         | Register                                                   |
|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| c. 110   | Ignatius predicates one subject of both births: Christ “both of Mary and of God” ( <i>Ephesians</i> 7, 18–19)     | Patristic witness to the substance; no title               |
| c. 180   | Irenaeus’s Eve–Mary recapitulation ( <i>AH</i> III.22.4; V.19.1)                                                  | Patristic theology; structural, not definitional           |
| disputed | <i>Sub tuum praesidium</i> : direct invocation of the <i>Theotokos</i> ; papyrus dating contested                 | Devotional witness; date unsettled                         |
| 428      | Anastasius’s sermon against <i>Theotokos</i> ; Nestorius defends it                                               | Reported occasion of the controversy                       |
| 430      | Celestine’s Roman synod condemns Nestorius; Cassian’s seven books; Cyril’s third letter with the twelve anathemas | Papal and patriarchal acts; anathemas at Cyril’s own level |



| Date     | Milestone                                                               | Register                                       |
|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| 431      | Ephesus approves Cyril’s second letter and deposes Nestorius            | Ecumenical council: the controlling act        |
| 433      | Formula of Reunion: “we confess the holy Virgin to be Mother of God”    | Negotiated confession received by both parties |
| c. 434   | Vincent of Lérins confesses the <i>Theotokos</i> in the Latin West      | Patristic reception                            |
| 451, 553 | Chalcedon’s Definition of Faith; Constantinople II’s anathemas (DS 427) | Conciliar reception and fixing                 |
| 1964     | LG 53 restates the title at the head of the Marian chapter              | Conciliar synthesis                            |

## 4 Ever-Virgin: the Perpetual Virginity

### The defined object and its authority

The dogma: Mary was and remained a virgin—in conceiving her Son (*ante partum*), in giving him birth (*in partu*), and ever after (*post partum*); she is *aeiparthenos*, “ever-virgin.” Unlike the other three dogmas, this one rests on no single defining act. It is ancient dogma taught by the Church’s universal tradition, confessed in the creeds (“born of the Virgin Mary”), asserted by the Second Council of Constantinople (553), which twice calls Mary Mother of God “and always a virgin” in its anathemas (DS 427), and given its most exact conciliar formulation by the Lateran Council of 649 under Pope Martin I—not an ecumenical council, but a papally confirmed synod whose third canon the Church has received as a standard statement of the dogma.<sup>32</sup>

#### Defined text — Lateran Council of 649, canon 3 (DS 503), Latin

“Si quis secundum sanctos Patres non confitetur proprie et secundum veritatem Dei genitricem sanctam semperque Virginem et immaculatam Mariam, utpote ipsum Deum Verbum specialiter et veraciter, qui a Deo Patre ante omnia saecula natus est, in ultimis saeculorum absque semine concepisse ex Spiritu Sancto, et incorruptibiliter eum genuisse, indissolubili permanente et post partum eiusdem virginitate, condemnatus sit.”<sup>33</sup>

The canon binds together all three moments: conception without seed by the Holy Spirit; incorrupt birth; virginity indissolubly permanent after birth. Note the canon’s own word *immaculatam*—an early witness to the language, though not to the 1854 definition’s object.

### Why a Marian canon stands in a synod about wills

The setting of that canon is regularly forgotten, and it explains the canon’s form. The Lateran Synod met from 5 to 31 October 649 under Martin I, and its business was Monothelitism: the imperial attempt, through the *Ecthesis* and the *Typos*, to settle the Christological question by conceding one will in Christ. The canons run in sequence through the Trinity (can. 1), the incarnation of the Word “of the Holy Spirit and Mary ever virgin” (can. 2), the divine motherhood and perpetual virginity (can. 3), the two nativities of the one Lord (can. 4), and onward to the two wills and two operations that were the synod’s actual object.<sup>34</sup> The Marian canon is therefore not a Marian decree; it is one clause of a complete Christological confession, drafted so that no Monothelite reading could shelter in an incomplete statement of who was born of the Virgin. The most exact formulation the tradition possesses was produced as collateral precision in somebody else’s argument—which is how much of Marian doctrine was in fact fixed.

The same is true of the West’s classic sentence on the birth itself. Leo the Great’s Tome to Flavian (449), received at Chalcedon and cited in the Catechism’s chain at DS 291, says of the Virgin that “she brought him forth with her virginity preserved, just as with her virginity preserved she conceived him”—a Christological letter written to refute Eutyches, in which the *in partu* clause appears as a premise, not a thesis.<sup>35</sup>

## Scripture, honestly weighted

Scripture directly teaches the virginal conception: Matthew 1:18–25 and Luke 1:26–35 assert it in narrative, and Mary’s own question—“How shall this be done, because I know not man?” (Lk 1:34)—presupposes it.<sup>36</sup> The full threefold confession is received through Tradition; Scripture neither states nor denies virginity in and after birth. The standing objections are old and must be answered at their own linguistic scale, not with knock-down certainty: the “brothers and sisters” of Jesus (Mk 6:3 etc.) use kinship terms whose range in the Semitic background is wider than sibling, and the Church has always understood these passages as not referring to other children of Mary—the Catechism notes that James and Joseph, “brothers of Jesus,” are elsewhere the sons of another Mary (CCC 500); Matthew’s “till she brought forth her firstborn son” (Mt 1:25) asserts what was true up to the birth without asserting a change after it, a normal Semitic usage; “firstborn” is a legal status of the child that opens the womb, not a count of siblings.<sup>37</sup>

## The fourth-century controversies: Helvidius and Jovinian

The doctrine was tested twice within twenty years at Rome, and by adversaries whose real target was not Mary. Helvidius argued from Matthew’s “before they came together” and “knew her not till she had brought forth,” and from the “brothers,” that Mary bore other children—and his conclusion, as Jerome’s reply makes explicit, served a thesis about the equal dignity of marriage and virginity. Jovinian, on trial at Rome soon after, pressed the same equality further. The tradition’s answer therefore had to do two things at once: defend the perpetual virginity, and avoid saying that marriage is impure. Jerome managed the first magnificently and the second badly, and a reference that admires his exegesis should say so.

Jerome’s *On the Perpetual Virginity of the Blessed Mary* (383) argues on four fronts, and each argument is still the argument used.

*Until.* “The words *knew* and *till* in the language of Holy Scripture are capable of a double meaning”—and he piles up cases where a terminal marker implies nothing about what follows: “Even to old age I am he” (Is 46:4); “Lo, I am with you always, even unto the end of the world” (Mt 28:20)—“Will the Lord then after the end of the world has come forsake His disciples?”; “he must reign, till he has put all enemies under his feet”—“Of course His reign will then commence in its fullness when His enemies begin to be under His feet.”<sup>38</sup>

*Firstborn.* “Every only begotten son is a first-born son, but not every first-born is an only begotten.” The proof is legal rather than lexical: Numbers 18:15 binds the redemption of “everything that opens the womb,” and the obligation falls at a month old—so a father cannot wait to see whether a second child arrives before owing the priest.<sup>39</sup>

*Brothers.* Jerome’s decisive move is a lexical taxonomy: “In Holy Scripture there are four kinds of brethren—by nature, race, kindred, love,” with Lot called Abraham’s brother and Jacob Laban’s as the governing cases; and the identification of the crucified women in John 19:25 (“his mother’s sister, Mary of Cleophas”) as the mother of James the Less, so that the “brothers” are the Lord’s cousins.<sup>40</sup>

*Joseph.* The argument’s boldest step is to extend virginity to Joseph: “You say that Mary did not continue a virgin: I claim still more, that Joseph himself on account of Mary was a virgin, so that from a virgin wedlock a virgin son was born.”<sup>41</sup>

Two honesties are owed. First, Jerome knew his case was an argument from tradition as much as from text: “Might I not array against you the whole series of ancient writers? Ignatius, Polycarp, Irenæus, Justin Martyr, and many other apostolic and eloquent men”—while dismissing the contrary witness of Tertullian with the remark that “he did not belong to the Church.”<sup>42</sup> Second, the treatise’s closing comparison of virginity and marriage (§§20–23) is a piece of fourth-century invective—the married woman at her mirror, “the prattling of infants, the noisy household”—which the Church’s own later teaching does not endorse. *Lumen gentium* and the Catechism read Mary’s virginity as the sign of God’s absolute initiative and of her undivided self-gift, not as a verdict on ordinary motherhood; the dogma Jerome defended stands, and his rhetoric about marriage does not.

## The three ancient solutions to the “brothers”

The kinship question admits exactly three historic answers, and the Church has defined none of them. Naming their patrons keeps the categories straight.

*The Epiphanian solution:* the “brothers” are Joseph’s children by a prior marriage. It is the reading presupposed by the second-century *Protevangelium of James*, which makes Joseph an old widower, and it became and remains the ordinary Eastern reading. Its strength is that it takes “brother” in the plain sense; its weakness is that its earliest support is an apocryphon of no biographical value.

*The Hieronymian solution:* they are cousins, sons of the other Mary—Jerome’s reading, received in the West and reflected in the Catechism’s own note that James and Joseph are “the sons of another Mary, a disciple of Christ,” and that they are “close relations of Jesus, according to an Old Testament expression” (CCC 500).<sup>43</sup>

*The Helvidian solution:* they are later children of Mary and Joseph. This one the Church has rejected, and rejects still; it is incompatible with the dogma.

Between the first two, nothing is defined, and this reference settles nothing. Thomas Aquinas, writing seven centuries later, states the Western position with the same structure Jerome used but a different emphasis: “Without any hesitation we must abhor the error of Helvidius,” because it is derogatory to Christ’s perfection as his mother’s only son, an insult to the Holy Ghost whose “shrine” the virginal womb was, and derogatory to the dignity and holiness of God’s Mother—who would otherwise have forfeited, of her own accord, a virginity miraculously preserved.<sup>44</sup>

## From confession to standing doctrine

The virginal conception is confessed from the earliest creeds and by Ignatius of Antioch (CCC 496–497). The *Protevangelium of James* already narrates virginity preserved in birth—apocryphal, worthless as biography, but weighty as evidence of what second-century Christians believed. From the fifth century *aeiparthenos* is standard; Leo’s Tome fixes the *in partu* clause in the West; Constantinople II and Lateran 649 fix the whole in conciliar and synodal language. The chain the Catechism cites reaches into the sixteenth century, where Paul IV’s constitution *Cum quorundam hominum* (1555; DS 1880) condemns those who deny that Christ was conceived “in the womb of the most blessed and ever Virgin Mary of the Holy Spirit” and hold instead that he was born “like other men, of the seed of Joseph.”<sup>45</sup> The ordinary universal magisterium has taught the dogma continuously since.

## What the dogma does and does not assert

It asserts a real, bodily, lifelong virginity, integral in the act of birth itself: the Second Vatican Council repeats the tradition that Christ’s birth “did not diminish His mother’s virginal integrity but sanctified it” (LG 57), and the Church celebrates Mary as *Aeiparthenos* (CCC 499).<sup>46</sup> It does not assert any anatomical or obstetric theory: the Church has never defined the physiology of the birth, and the dogma is not a medical claim. It does not assert that marriage or childbirth is impure—the tradition reads Mary’s virginity as the sign of her undivided gift of self and of God’s absolute initiative in the Incarnation (CCC 502–506), not as a judgment on ordinary motherhood. And it does not depend on contempt for the “brothers of the Lord,” who remain real kinsmen of Jesus in the Church’s reading. The common misunderstanding—that the dogma stands or falls with a single proof-text—mistakes its mode: it is Tradition’s dogma, formulated conciliarly, in which Scripture is read within the Church’s rule of faith.

## Development milestones

The medieval professions of faith carry the formula forward without argument, which is itself the evidence: the Second Council of Lyons (1274) has the emperor Michael profess the Son “temporally born of the Holy Spirit and Mary ever Virgin,” and the Council of Florence’s decree for the Jacobites (1442) confesses that he took human nature “from the immaculate womb of the Virgin Mary.”<sup>47</sup>

| Date       | Milestone                                                                                                        | Register                                                 |
|------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| c. 110–180 | Creeds and Ignatius confess the virginal conception; <i>Protevangelium</i> narrates virginity preserved in birth | Credal confession; apocryphal reception evidence         |
| 383        | Jerome against Helvidius: <i>donec, primogenitus</i> , the four kinds of brethren, Joseph’s virginity            | Patristic controversy; theological argument              |
| 449/451    | Leo’s Tome (DS 291), received at Chalcedon: conceived and borne with virginity preserved                         | Papal doctrinal letter received by an ecumenical council |

| Date       | Milestone                                                                                                    | Register                                      |
|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| 553        | Constantinople II calls her Mother of God “and always a virgin” (DS 427)                                     | Ecumenical council                            |
| 649        | Lateran Synod, can. 3 (DS 503): the exact threefold formulation, inside an anti-Monothelite confession       | Papally confirmed synod; received as standard |
| 1274, 1442 | Lyons II (DS 852) professes “Maria semper Virgine”; Florence (DS 1337) “ex immaculato utero Mariae Virginis” | Conciliar professions of faith                |
| 1555       | <i>Cum quorundam hominum</i> (DS 1880) condemns denial of the virginal conception                            | Papal constitution                            |
| 1964       | LG 57: the birth “did not diminish His mother’s virginal integrity but sanctified it”                        | Conciliar synthesis                           |
| 1992       | CCC 499–500, 510 states the doctrine and the kinship reading without settling the two ancient solutions      | Catechetical framing                          |

## 5 Conceived Without Sin: the Immaculate Conception

### The defined text and its authority

On 8 December 1854, in the apostolic constitution *Ineffabilis Deus*, Pius IX defined:

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Defined text — <i>Ineffabilis Deus</i>, Pius IX, 8 December 1854 (DS 2803)</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| “We declare, pronounce, and define that the doctrine which holds that the most Blessed Virgin Mary, in the first instance of her conception, by a singular grace and privilege granted by Almighty God, in view of the merits of Jesus Christ, the Savior of the human race, was preserved free from all stain of original sin, is a doctrine revealed by God and therefore to be believed firmly and constantly by all the faithful.” <sup>48</sup> |

The constitution continues with a formal sanction: whoever “shall dare—which God forbid!—to think otherwise than as has been defined by us” is “condemned by his own judgment,” has “suffered shipwreck in the faith,” has “separated from the unity of the Church,” and incurs the penalties of law if he expresses the error outwardly (DS 2804).<sup>49</sup> The level is the highest: a solemn papal definition of divinely revealed doctrine, binding the whole Church.

### Reading the definition’s clauses

Every phrase is load-bearing. “In the first instance of her conception”: the grace touches Mary’s origin itself, not a later cleansing. “Singular grace and privilege”: unique to her; the definition creates no general class. “In view of the merits of Jesus Christ” (*intuitu meritorum*): the decisive clause—Mary is not exempt from redemption but is its most perfect case, redeemed by anticipation, preserved rather than rescued. “Preserved free from all stain of original sin”: the object is original sin only; Mary’s lifelong freedom from personal sin is a closely related but distinct teaching, not the thing defined here (CCC 493).<sup>50</sup> And “is a doctrine revealed by God”: the definition claims not to add to revelation but to declare what the deposit contains—the claim on which the ecumenical difficulty chiefly turns (Chapter 9).

### Scripture, honestly weighted

The definition names no proof-text in its defining sentence; the constitution’s own survey reads two loci within Tradition, both treated at length in Chapter 2 above. Genesis 3:15, the enmity God sets “between thee and the woman, and thy seed and her seed,” is read by the Fathers and by the constitution as foretelling the Redeemer and prophetically indicating his Mother, joined without compromise to the serpent’s defeat—the argument resting on the enmity, not on the disputed *ipsa* of the Vulgate.<sup>51</sup> Luke 1:28, Gabriel’s greeting, transliterated *kecharitomene*, is a perfect passive participle of *charitoo*: the greeting names Mary as one already graced. The word alone does not state the 1854 dogma; the Church reads it cumulatively, as the Catechism does (CCC 490–491), within the tradition of

Mary's singular holiness.<sup>52</sup> The constitution itself adds a long catena of figures—the ark that survived the flood, Jacob's ladder, the burning bush, the tower of David, the enclosed garden, the city of God—and presents them for what they are: the way the Fathers taught that Mary's dignity “had been prophesied in a wonderful manner,” not a set of demonstrations.

## The patristic matrix, and what it does not contain

The patristic centuries supply a matrix, not the formula: the New Eve parallel from Justin and Irenaeus onward, the East's praise of Mary as all-holy (*Panagia*), the language of Lateran 649 (*immaculatam*), the Eastern feast of Mary's conception. No pre-Nicene Father states the first-instant formula. Augustine's famous exemption of Mary—“out of honor to the Lord” he would raise no question of sin about her—concerns personal sin, not the conception, and *Ineffabilis Deus* itself cites the passage only in the section on the Fathers' praise of her sanctity.<sup>53</sup> What the Fathers give the later Church is a habit of speech—“immaculate in every respect; innocent, and verily most innocent; spotless, and entirely spotless”—which the constitution itself describes as “a singular and truly marvelous style of speech” that “passed almost spontaneously into the books of the most holy liturgy.” A style of speech is real evidence about belief and is not a definition; the constitution's argument is that the Church would not have prayed that way about a soul once subject to sin.

## The medieval debate, on its own terms

Between the twelfth and the fifteenth centuries the doctrine was genuinely contested by saints on both sides, and the contest was not about Mary's holiness—all parties affirmed that—but about how a sinless origin could be squared with the universality of redemption. The Church defined only after the difficulty had been answered, and the record of the difficulty belongs to the dogma's history.

*Bernard of Clairvaux* objected, about 1140, to the canons of Lyons for adopting the feast of the Conception. His letter is the classic statement of the negative case, and it is more interesting than its reputation. He grants everything except the point at issue: Mary's birth was holy, “for the mother of the Lord also was holy before birth,” and he holds it “most firmly with the Church, that she received in the womb that she should come into the world holy.” What he denies is that holiness can attach to the conception itself: “how can there be sanctity without the sanctifying Spirit, or the co-operation of the Holy Spirit with sin? . . . it remains to be believed that she received sanctification when existing in the womb after conception, which, by excluding sin, made her birth holy, but not her conception.” He objects to the feast as “a presumptuous novelty against the custom of the Church”; he complains that it was introduced without consulting Rome; and—the sentence that his later critics rarely quote—he closes: “I refer the whole of it, as of all matters of a similar kind, to the authority and decision of the See of Rome, and I am prepared to modify my opinion if in anything I think otherwise than that See.”<sup>54</sup>

*Thomas Aquinas* inherited Bernard's problem and sharpened it. His position, stated exactly, is this. Mary was sanctified in the womb before birth—a conclusion he reaches by an argument from fittingness, since “nothing is handed down in the canonical Scriptures concerning the sanctification of the Blessed Mary as to her being sanctified in the womb; indeed, they do not even mention her birth.”<sup>55</sup> But sanctification before animation he denies, and for two reasons: grace presupposes a rational subject, so “before the infusion of the rational soul” there is nothing to sanctify; and if she had been sanctified before animation “she could never have incurred the stain of original sin: and thus she would not have needed redemption and salvation which is by Christ.” His reply to the second objection states the principle without qualification: “If the soul of the Blessed Virgin had never incurred the stain of original sin, this would be derogatory to the dignity of Christ, by reason of His being the universal Saviour of all.”<sup>56</sup> On the feast, Thomas is a witness to the state of the Roman question in his own day: “although the Church of Rome does not celebrate the Conception of the Blessed Virgin, yet it tolerates the custom of certain churches that do keep that feast”—and, he adds, what is kept on that day is better called the feast of her Sanctification.<sup>57</sup>

*John Duns Scotus* supplied the resolution the definition received. Preservation is the more perfect mode of redemption: Christ, the most perfect Mediator, could preserve his Mother from contracting original sin, and preserving grace is a greater debt to his merits than liberating grace. The tag *potuit, decuit, fecit*—“he could, it was fitting, he did it”—summarizes the argument but is a later schoolroom formula, not a checked verbatim quotation of Scotus.<sup>58</sup> The schools then divided for two centuries, Franciscans generally for and Dominicans generally against; *Ineffabilis Deus* alludes to the settlement of that dispute only in the summary form that the doctrine came to be “handed down,

proposed and defended by the most outstanding religious orders, by the more celebrated theological academies, and by very eminent doctors.”<sup>59</sup>

## Rome steers the question, 1476–1854

The papacy’s role before 1854 was not to define but to keep the dispute from tearing the Church, and the sequence is instructive.

*Sixtus IV* approved a Mass and Office of the Conception (*Cum praeexcelsa*) and then, in *Grave nimis*, forbade the parties to brand each other heretics—explicitly condemning as “false and erroneous” the assertion that those who hold the preservation are sinning or heretical, and censuring equally those who called the contrary opinion heretical.<sup>60</sup>

*Trent*, defining original sin in 1546, inserted a declaration that it did not intend to include Mary: “this same holy Synod declares that it is not its intention to include in this decree, where original sin is treated of, the blessed and immaculate Virgin Mary, Mother of God, but that the constitutions of Pope Sixtus IV of happy memory are to be observed.”<sup>61</sup>

*Paul V* (1617) and *Gregory XV* (1622) forbade public and then even private assertion of the contrary opinion. *Alexander VII*, in *Sollicitudo omnium ecclesiarum* of 8 December 1661, fixed the object of the feast with the wording that 1854 would echo almost exactly: the ancient devotion of the faithful holds that Mary’s soul, “in the first instant of its creation and of its infusion into the body, was, by a special grace and privilege of God, in view of the merits of Jesus Christ her Son, the Redeemer of the human race, preserved immune from the stain of original sin.”<sup>62</sup>

*Pius IX* then consulted the episcopate. On 2 February 1849, from Gaeta, he sent *Ubi primum* asking the bishops what the piety and devotion of their faithful was, “what the bishops themselves thought about defining this doctrine and what their wishes were in regard to making known with all possible solemnity our supreme judgment.” The replies, the constitution says, asked “with one voice” for the definition.<sup>63</sup>

## How the constitution argues

Read whole, *Ineffabilis Deus* is not a proof-text argument at all. Its order is: the divine maternity as the supreme reason for the privilege; the liturgical argument (the Church would not celebrate the feast of a conception unless that conception were holy); the ordinary teaching and the acts of the Roman pontiffs; the testimony of the Catholic world and of Trent; the testimonies of Tradition; then the Fathers as interpreters of Scripture (Gen 3:15, Lk 1:28, the figures); then the preparation, the consultation, and the definition. The argument is cumulative and ecclesial, and it is explicit about the principle of development that licenses it—in words taken, without attribution, from Vincent of Lérins: the Church “never changes anything, never diminishes anything, never adds anything,” but explains the ancient documents so that the dogmas “will grow only within their own genus— that is, within the same dogma, in the same sense and the same meaning.”<sup>64</sup> That sentence is the hinge of the whole question—whether a Church can define in 1854 what no Father stated in 451—and the constitution answers it in the only way a Catholic answer can be given: not by producing an early formula, but by claiming that the formula makes explicit what the Church always believed.

## Four years later: Lourdes

On 25 March 1858 at Lourdes, in the sixteenth of the reported apparitions, the girl Bernadette Soubirous reported that the figure she saw named herself in Gascon with words she did not understand, and which her parish priest and the subsequent record rendered “I am the Immaculate Conception.” The Catholic reading of that sentence—that the dogma of 1854 was confirmed from heaven—is not part of the dogma and cannot be: the definition rests on the deposit of faith, not on a private revelation later than the apostolic age, and the local judgment of 1862 established the apparitions’ credibility, not the dogma. The proper order runs the other way: the definition of 1854 is the standard by which the reported sentence of 1858 was itself judged intelligible.<sup>65</sup>

## What the dogma does and does not assert

It asserts Mary's preservation from original sin from the first instant, by grace, through Christ's merits. It does not assert that Mary needed no redeemer—it asserts the opposite, in terms. It does not concern the virginal conception of Jesus, with which it is perennially confused: the Immaculate Conception is Mary's own conception by her parents in the ordinary way, immaculate in grace, not in manner. It does not define Mary's freedom from concupiscence's effects in detail, her exemption from bodily death, or any physiological claim. And it does not make the medieval doctors' hesitation retroactively heretical: the Church defined after the development, and the honest record of Bernard's and Thomas's difficulty is part of the dogma's history, preserved in this reference as the profile requires. Current catechesis: CCC 490–493, 508; LG 56, 59.

## Development milestones

| Date                 | Milestone                                                                                                                  | Register                                                              |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2nd c. onward<br>649 | New Eve parallel (Justin, Irenaeus); Eastern <i>Panagia</i> praise<br>Lateran can. 3 calls Mary <i>immaculatam</i>         | Patristic matrix; no formula<br>Synodal language, not the 1854 object |
| c. 1140              | Bernard's letter to the canons of Lyons against the feast, closing with submission to Rome                                 | Theological objection by a Doctor                                     |
| by c. 1270           | A feast of the Conception kept in some churches; Rome tolerating rather than keeping it ( <i>ST</i> III, q. 27, a. 2 ad 3) | Liturgical reception, reported by a witness of the period             |
| c. 1270              | Thomas: sanctified in the womb, not before animation ( <i>ST</i> III, q. 27)                                               | Real Thomistic limit                                                  |
| c. 1300              | Scotus: preservative redemption is the more perfect redemption                                                             | Theological resolution                                                |
| 1476–1483            | Sixtus IV: Office approved; <i>Grave nimis</i> forbids either side to brand the other heretical                            | Papal constitutions; disciplinary                                     |
| 1546                 | Trent declares it does not include Mary in its decree on original sin (DS 1516)                                            | Conciliar non-inclusion                                               |
| 1617, 1622           | Paul V and Gregory XV restrict assertion of the contrary opinion                                                           | Disciplinary acts                                                     |
| 1661                 | Alexander VII fixes the feast's object at the first instant (DS 2015–2017)                                                 | Papal constitution; object fixed, not defined                         |
| 1849                 | <i>Ubi primum</i> consults the episcopate                                                                                  | Papal consultation                                                    |
| 1854                 | <i>Ineffabilis Deus</i> defines (DS 2803–2804)                                                                             | Solemn <i>ex cathedra</i> definition                                  |
| 1858                 | Lourdes: the reported self-naming, judged locally in 1862                                                                  | Private revelation; no dogmatic force                                 |
| 1964, 1992           | LG 56, 59 and CCC 490–493 restate the doctrine Christologically                                                            | Conciliar and catechetical framing                                    |

## 6 Assumed into Glory: the Assumption

### The defined text and its authority

On 1 November 1950, in the apostolic constitution *Munificentissimus Deus*, Pius XII defined:

**Defined text — *Munificentissimus Deus*, Pius XII, 1 November 1950, §44 (DS 3903)**

“...by the authority of our Lord Jesus Christ, of the Blessed Apostles Peter and Paul, and by our own authority, we pronounce, declare, and define it to be a divinely revealed dogma: that the Immaculate Mother of God, the ever Virgin Mary, having completed the course of her earthly life, was assumed body and soul into heavenly glory.”<sup>66</sup>

The sanction follows immediately: anyone who “should dare willfully to deny or to call into doubt that which we have defined” has “fallen away completely from the divine and Catholic Faith” (§45; DS 3904).<sup>67</sup> This is the one exercise of the solemn *ex cathedra* mode after its 1870 definition, and the definition names its own title to the deposit: a truth “based on the Sacred Writings, . . . thoroughly rooted in the minds of the faithful, . . . approved in ecclesiastical worship from the most remote times, . . . completely in harmony with the other revealed truths” (§41).

Note also the definition’s opening words: it defines something about “the Immaculate Mother of God, the ever Virgin Mary.” The subject of the 1950 sentence is the woman of the other three dogmas, and the constitution says outright why: “these two privileges are most closely bound to one another,” since she who “completely overcame sin by her Immaculate Conception” was “not subject to the law of remaining in the corruption of the grave” (§§4–5). The last dogma defined is the one that presupposes the rest.<sup>68</sup>

## The 1946 consultation

The definition rests on a formal consultation of the whole episcopate, and the document that opened it is short enough to characterize exactly. On 1 May 1946 Pius XII sent the bishops of the world the letter *Deiparae Virginis Mariae*. It recounts that petitions for the definition had reached the Holy See over a century—“those received from 1849 to 1940 have been gathered in two volumes”—and that “almost two hundred fathers in the Vatican Council” had asked for it. Then it puts two questions, and only two: whether the bishops, “with your learning and prudence, consider that the bodily Assumption of the Immaculate Blessed Virgin can be proposed and defined as a dogma of faith,” and “whether in addition to your own wishes this is desired by your clergy and people.”<sup>69</sup>

The two questions are distinct, and the distinction is doctrinal: the first asks whether the doctrine belongs to the deposit and is definable, the second whether it is believed and desired. *MD* §12 reports an “almost unanimous affirmative response to both,” and then reasons from it in a way that repays attention: the agreement of the bishops with their faithful “shows us the concordant teaching of the Church’s ordinary doctrinal authority and the concordant faith of the Christian people,” and therefore “by itself and in an entirely certain and infallible way, manifests this privilege as a truth revealed by God.”<sup>70</sup> The solemn definition, on this account, does not create the certainty; it declares a certainty already constituted by the ordinary universal magisterium—which is why the 1950 act is the textbook case of a papal definition of something the whole Church already believed.

## The dormition traditions, honestly

There is no apostolic narrative of Mary’s end. What exists from late antiquity is a family of apocryphal narratives—the *Transitus Mariae* literature, surviving in Greek, Latin, Syriac, Coptic, and other versions, of which the best known circulates under the name of John the Theologian and tells of the apostles gathered miraculously from their missions to her deathbed. These texts are evidence of what believers in their milieu held; they are not evidence of what happened, and this reference does not use them as history.<sup>71</sup>

The Church’s own judgment on them is on record and is unflattering. The Roman list of books received and not received known as the *Decretum Gelasianum* places among the apocrypha “the book which is called the Assumption of holy Mary”—classed *apocryphus*, in a list that also rejects the infancy gospels.<sup>72</sup> The belief in Mary’s glorification therefore cannot be derived from the *Transitus* texts: the same Church that held the belief refused the books.

This is exactly the structure *Munificentissimus Deus* adopts. Its historical argument runs through liturgy and teaching, not narrative, and the constitution’s English text nowhere cites the *Transitus* literature at all—a checked absence.<sup>73</sup>

## The liturgical argument

The feast is the load-bearing evidence, and the constitution assembles it carefully. In the East the day is the *Koimesis*, the falling asleep; in the West the Assumption; the constitution treats the two names as naming one belief and quotes both traditions. From the sacramentary that Adrian I sent to Charlemagne: “Venerable to us, O Lord, is the festivity of this day on which the holy Mother of God suffered temporal death, but still could not be kept down by the bonds of death.” From the Gallican books: the privilege is “an ineffable mystery all the more worthy of praise as the Virgin’s Assumption is something unique among men.” From the Byzantine liturgy: “As he kept you a virgin in childbirth, thus he has kept your body incorrupt in the tomb and has glorified it by his divine act of transferring it



from the tomb.”<sup>74</sup> To this it adds the feast’s rise in Roman practice—Sergius I prescribing the stational procession on four Marian feasts including the Dormition, Leo IV adding a vigil and an octave, Nicholas I attesting the preceding fast—and the ordinary argument that the Apostolic See would not have solemnized what the Church did not believe.<sup>75</sup>

The eighth-century preachers then state the belief explicitly, above all John Damascene: “It was fitting that she, who had kept her virginity intact in childbirth, should keep her own body free from all corruption even after death.”<sup>76</sup>

## The scholastic argument and the Thomistic limit

The medieval theologians argued from fittingness, and the constitution reports their reasoning in that register: Amadeus of Lausanne on the flesh that “remained incorrupt”; Anthony of Padua, Albert the Great, Bonaventure, Bernardine of Siena; and, later, Robert Bellarmine and Francis de Sales, the latter arguing from the commandment to honor one’s parents—“What son would not bring his mother back to life?”—which is a rhetorical question, not a demonstration.<sup>77</sup>

On Thomas the constitution is exact and modest: he “never dealt directly with this question,” yet whenever he touched it held with the Church that Mary’s body was assumed with her soul (§31). This reference claims no more—and notes, from the other side, that Thomas’s own treatment of the Immaculate Conception argues by analogy from a tractate on the Assumption which he ascribes to Augustine, so that the Assumption functioned for him as the securer of a less certain belief rather than as a conclusion needing support.<sup>78</sup>

## Scripture, honestly weighted

There is no Assumption narrative in the New Testament, and the constitution claims none. Its stated position is that the proofs of the Fathers and theologians are “based upon the Sacred Writings as their ultimate foundation”: Scripture sets the Mother inseparably beside her Son and his lot (§38); from the second century she is the new Eve, associated with the new Adam in the struggle foretold in the protoevangelium (Gen 3:15), a struggle ending in victory over sin *and death*, as Paul’s resurrection texts announce (§39; cf. 1 Cor 15:54–57). Psalm 132, the Canticle, Revelation 12, and the other loci the tradition uses appear in the constitution as the theologians’ figures, reported as such (§§26–27; Chapter 2 above). The scriptural case is thus a canonical and Christological horizon within which Tradition’s testimony is read—not a chain of narrative proof-texts, and the constitution is candid about that structure.<sup>79</sup>

## What was deliberately left open

The definition says “having completed the course of her earthly life” (*expleto terrestres vitae cursu*)—and stops. It does not define whether Mary died. The constitution freely reports the tradition of her death: the liturgical books treat “the dormition or the Assumption”; the Roman prayer it quotes says she “suffered temporal death”; the faithful, it says, found it “not difficult . . . to admit that the great Mother of God, like her only begotten Son, had actually passed from this life,” while holding that her body never saw corruption; and John Damascene, its chief witness, speaks of incorruption “even after death.”<sup>80</sup> Yet the defining sentence was drawn so as to leave the question open, and theologians on both sides have since argued it legitimately: one position holds that she truly died and was raised—the reading the liturgy and the Fathers cited by the constitution presuppose—while the other holds that she passed to glory without death. Both are theological opinions compatible with the definition, and this reference settles neither.

The dogma likewise does not state where or when the Assumption occurred, does not canonize any *Transitus* narrative, does not locate or authenticate any tomb, and does not assert that Mary’s glorification bypassed the common human end—only that, however her earthly course was completed, she was taken up body and soul.

## What the dogma does and does not assert

It asserts that Mary, body and soul, already shares the glory of her Son’s Resurrection. It does not assert an ascension: Christ ascended by his own power; Mary was *assumed*, taken up by God’s act—the passive is doctrinal. It is not an apotheosis: she remains a creature, glorified wholly by grace. It does not add a fifth article about her death, her final illness, or a tomb. Its doctrinal fruit is eschatological and ecclesial: the Assumption is “a singular participation in her Son’s Resurrection” and an anticipation of the resurrection promised to all members of his Body (CCC 966, quoting

LG 59; CCC 974); in Mary the Church contemplates what she herself will be (CCC 972). The constitution’s own closing hope is the same: “belief in Mary’s bodily Assumption into heaven will make our belief in our own resurrection stronger.”<sup>81</sup>

## Development milestones

| Date                         | Milestone                                                                                                                    | Register                                             |
|------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| 1st–4th c.<br>late antiquity | Canonical silence on Mary’s end; no apostolic narrative<br><i>Transitus Mariae</i> narratives circulate in several languages | Checked absence<br>Apocryphal reception; not history |
| 6th c.<br>(disputed)         | <i>Decretum Gelasianum</i> lists “the Assumption of holy Mary” among the apocrypha                                           | Roman list of rejected books                         |
| 7th–9th c.                   | Feast of the Dormition/Assumption solemnized at Rome (Sergius I, Leo IV, Nicholas I)                                         | Liturgical reception, reported by <i>MD</i>          |
| 8th c.                       | John Damascene and the great homilists teach the belief explicitly                                                           | Patristic preaching                                  |
| 12th–15th c.                 | Scholastic arguments from fittingness (Amadeus, Anthony, Albert, Bonaventure, Bernardine)                                    | Theological reasoning                                |
| 1849–1940                    | Petitions to the Holy See gathered in two volumes                                                                            | Documented <i>sensus fidelium</i>                    |
| 1869–70                      | Almost two hundred Fathers of the First Vatican Council petition for a definition                                            | Petition, not act                                    |
| 1 May 1946                   | <i>Deiparae Virginis Mariae</i> asks the world’s bishops two questions                                                       | Papal consultation (privately circulated)            |
| 1 Nov. 1950                  | <i>Munificentissimus Deus</i> defines (DS 3903–3904)                                                                         | Solemn <i>ex cathedra</i> definition                 |
| 1964, 1992                   | LG 59, 68 and CCC 966, 972–974 read the dogma eschatologically                                                               | Conciliar and catechetical framing                   |

## 7 How the Four Cohere

Four dogmas defined across fifteen centuries, in three different modes, by councils and popes answering unrelated crises, might have been four unrelated facts. They are not, and the coherence is not a devotional impression but a structure the Church’s own documents state. This chapter sets it out: first the Christological rule that governs every Marian dogma; then the order in which the four stand to one another; then the ecclesial and eschatological meaning that *Lumen gentium* draws from the whole.

### The Christological rule

Every one of the four was defined, or formulated, inside an argument about Christ—not beside one.

The divine motherhood was defined at Ephesus to protect the unity of the one Christ against a division of the subject. The perpetual virginity received its exact formulation in canon 3 of a synod convened against Monothelitism, in a sequence of canons stating who the incarnate Word is; its *in partu* clause reached the West as a premise inside Leo’s letter against Eutyches. The Immaculate Conception is defined “in view of the merits of Jesus Christ, the Savior of the human race”—a clause that makes the dogma a statement about the reach of the Redemption before it is a statement about Mary. The Assumption is defined of “the Immaculate Mother of God, the ever Virgin Mary,” and is argued from the victory over sin and death won by the new Adam in whose struggle the new Eve is associated.

From this a working rule follows, and it is the rule this reference has applied throughout: *no Marian dogma states anything about Mary that is not first a statement about Christ or about the effect of his grace*. Cyril’s first anathema exhibits the rule in its grammar—“the Emmanuel is very God, and *therefore* the Holy Virgin is the Mother of God”—and the Second Vatican Council restates it as a norm for teaching: the Council “does not, however, have it in mind to give a complete doctrine on Mary,” and it exhorts theologians and preachers “to abstain zealously both from all gross exaggerations as well as from petty narrow-mindedness in considering the singular dignity of the Mother

of God,” and to illustrate her duties and privileges in a way that “always look[s] to Christ, the source of all truth, sanctity and piety.”<sup>82</sup>

## The order among the four

The four are not four parallel privileges but one sequence with a single principle—and the sequence runs in two directions at once.

*Ontologically, from the motherhood outward.* Because the Son she bore is God in person, she is *Theotokos*; everything else is a consequence of what that motherhood required and what it merited by Christ’s grace. The perpetual virginity states that this motherhood was whole and undivided, God’s initiative and her total self-gift. The Immaculate Conception states what grace had to do, and did, at the origin of the one who would give the Word his flesh. The Assumption states what became of the body that bore him. *Ineffabilis Deus* makes the motherhood explicitly the “supreme reason for the privilege”: “it was wholly fitting that so wonderful a mother should be ever resplendent with the glory of most sublime holiness.”<sup>83</sup>

*Chronologically, from the last defined backwards.* The 1950 definition presupposes 1854 and says so (§§4–5); 1854 presupposes the divine motherhood as its supreme reason; the Lateran canon of 649 states motherhood and virginity in one breath. Each later act quotes the earlier ones into its own operative sentence. That is why the four cannot be taken à la carte: the subject of the 1950 sentence is defined by the other three.

There is a further, harder unity. In all four, what is affirmed of Mary is *received*. She is Mother of God by God’s choice and the Spirit’s overshadowing; virgin by grace; immaculate by a preserving grace granted in view of another’s merits; assumed by God’s act, not her own ascent. The passive voice runs through every operative formula in this reference’s definitions table, and it is the strongest single argument against every construction of Marian doctrine that would make her an independent source (Chapter 8).

## Mary as the eschatological icon of the Church

The Second Vatican Council’s Marian chapter ends by drawing out what the four dogmas mean for everyone else, and this is where the coherence becomes pastoral rather than merely architectural.

LG 63 states the type: “As St. Ambrose taught, the Mother of God is a type of the Church in the order of faith, charity and perfect union with Christ,” and “in the mystery of the Church, which is itself rightly called mother and virgin, the Blessed Virgin stands out in eminent and singular fashion as exemplar both of virgin and mother.” LG 64 completes the parallel from the Church’s side: the Church, “by receiving the word of God in faith becomes herself a mother,” and “she herself is a virgin, who keeps the faith given to her by her Spouse whole and entire.”<sup>84</sup>

LG 65 then states the difference that keeps the analogy from becoming flattery: “while in the most holy Virgin the Church has already reached that perfection whereby she is without spot or wrinkle, the followers of Christ still strive to increase in holiness by conquering sin.” In Mary the Church sees her own completed state; in herself she sees the struggle. And LG 68 draws the eschatological conclusion: “just as the Mother of Jesus, glorified in body and soul in heaven, is the image and beginning of the Church as it is to be perfected is the world to come, so too does she shine forth on earth . . . as a sign of sure hope and solace to the people of God during its sojourn on earth.”<sup>85</sup>

Read through that lens, each dogma has an ecclesial translation which is not a demotion of its Marian sense but its purpose. The divine motherhood grounds the Church’s confession of the one Christ. The perpetual virginity images the Church’s undivided fidelity to her Spouse. The Immaculate Conception shows what grace can do, and does, at the root of a creature—the Church’s own destiny of holiness, realized already in one member. The Assumption shows the body’s share in that destiny, and therefore what the resurrection of the flesh will mean for the rest.

## What the coherence does not license

Three cautions belong to any synthesis of this kind, and they follow from the same documents.

The coherence is not a method for generating new dogmas. That the four fit together beautifully is an argument for their truth, not a warrant for extrapolating a fifth from the pattern; the Church defines from the deposit, not from symmetry (Chapter 8).

The typology is not exegesis. Mary as type of the Church is a theological reading grounded in conciliar teaching, not a claim about what the evangelists intended; Mary as new Eve is a patristic figure with its own history, not a proposition read off Genesis.

And the analogy runs one way. The Church is like Mary because Mary received Christ first and wholly; Mary is not made large by being identified with the Church. *Lumen gentium* keeps the asymmetry by placing its whole Marian chapter inside the constitution on the Church rather than issuing a separate Marian document—a structural decision of the Council which is itself part of the doctrine.<sup>86</sup>

## 8 The Boundary of the Defined: Titles, Doctrines, Opinions

### Authoritative teaching that is not a fifth dogma

Several firm Marian teachings stand near the four dogmas without being among them, and a reference must keep the categories visible. Mary’s freedom from personal sin throughout her life is constant authoritative teaching (CCC 493: “By the grace of God Mary remained free of every personal sin her whole life long”) but is not the object of the 1854 definition. Her spiritual motherhood of the faithful and the title Mother of the Church (proclaimed by Paul VI in 1964, echoed at CCC 963, 975) are authoritative teaching. Her Queenship is taught by the Assumption definition’s own horizon and by LG 59 (“exalted by the Lord as Queen of the universe”), yet no separate coronation dogma exists. Each of these binds in its own mode; none carries the four dogmas’ definitional form.<sup>87</sup>

### Cooperation, mediation, and the disputed titles

Mary’s cooperation in the work of salvation is real and conciliar doctrine: she “cooperated by her obedience, faith, hope, and burning charity in the Savior’s work,” and is “a mother to us in the order of grace” (LG 61, quoted at CCC 968). But the Council fenced the language on every side. There is “but one Mediator” (1 Tim 2:5; LG 60), and Mary’s maternal role “in no wise obscures or diminishes this unique mediation of Christ, but rather shows His power”; her influence “flows forth from the superabundance of the merits of Christ, rests on His mediation, depends entirely on it and draws all its power from it” (LG 60). The Church does invoke her “under the titles of Advocate, Auxiliatrix, Adjutrix, and Mediatrix,” yet “this, however, is to be so understood that it neither takes away from nor adds anything to the dignity and efficaciousness of Christ the one Mediator” (LG 62).<sup>88</sup>

The proposal to define a fifth Marian dogma—Mary as Co-redemptrix, Mediatrix of All Graces, and Advocate—has circulated in petition movements since the twentieth century. It stands *outside* the four dogmas, and the Holy See has now judged its central title directly. The Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith’s doctrinal note *Mater Populi Fidelis*, approved by Pope Leo XIV on 7 October 2025 and published 4 November 2025, concludes that “it is always inappropriate to use the title ‘Co-redemptrix’ to define Mary’s cooperation,” because the title “risks obscuring Christ’s unique salvific mediation” (§22). On mediation it teaches that the Council deliberately preferred the language of cooperation and maternal assistance (§27); on “Mediatrix of All Graces” it observes that Mary, “the first redeemed, could not have been the mediatrix of the grace that she herself received” (§67), while allowing that her intercession may implore the “actual graces” that prepare and accompany conversion (§69).<sup>89</sup> *Advocate*, retained by LG 62, means Mary’s maternal intercession within Christ’s mediation—never protection from a merciless Father or a reluctant Christ.

### Why the four are four

It is worth stating plainly why this reference treats exactly four, since the count is sometimes taken for an arbitrary convention. A dogma, by the criterion of *Dei Filius* quoted in Chapter 1, is a truth contained in revelation and *proposed as divinely revealed* by the Church, whether solemnly or through the ordinary and universal magisterium. Each of the four meets both halves of that test: the content is proposed as revealed, and there is an act or an established universal teaching that so proposes it. The teachings surveyed just above fail the second half, not the first—the Church teaches them, and teaches them authoritatively, without proposing them in that mode. That is the whole of the difference, and it is a difference in the mode of proposal, not a ranking of Mary’s dignities.

Three practical consequences follow for a reader trying to sort claims. A liturgical feast establishes that the Church celebrates something, not that she has defined it—the feast of the Conception existed for centuries while the doctrine was disputed (Chapter 5). A papal or conciliar usage of a title establishes that the title was used with that authority on that date, not that its content is defined—which is why *Mater Populi Fidelis* can review earlier papal uses of “Co-redemptrix” and still judge the title inappropriate for present constructive use. And widespread devotion, however fervent and however long, establishes the *sensus fidelium* as one element among the others that the magisterium weighs; in 1854 and 1950 it was weighed and found sufficient, and in the case of the proposed fifth dogma it has not been.

The doctrinal test that governs every Marian title follows from the four dogmas themselves: whatever is said of Mary must be received, created, participated, and wholly dependent on the one Redeemer. Said that way, the titles guard the dogmas; said otherwise, they obscure them. That is the boundary this reference draws, and it is the Church’s own.

## 9 Reception and Ecumenical Boundaries

Two of the four dogmas are held, in substance, by Christians who are not in communion with Rome; two are contested, and contested for reasons that are not primarily about Mary. A reference that states the Catholic doctrine owes its reader an accurate map of where the disagreement actually lies. This chapter draws it from the other communions’ own documents wherever such documents could be identified, and marks the level of each.

### The Orthodox East

The Christological dogmas are common ground, and the shared inheritance is not a modern convergence but the same councils. The Orthodox Churches confess the *Theotokos* of Ephesus and Chalcedon, keep the *aeiparthenos* of Constantinople II, celebrate the Dormition (*Koimesis*) on 15 August, and honor Mary in a liturgical register at least as rich as the Latin one. *Lumen gentium* 69 registers the fact with evident relief: the Council rejoices that among the separated brethren “especially among the Orientals,” many “with devout mind and fervent impulse give honor to the Mother of God, ever virgin.”<sup>90</sup>

The difficulty is the Immaculate Conception, and the 1854 definition drew an explicit answer. In 1895 the Ecumenical Patriarch Anthimus VII and his synod replied to Leo XIII’s *Praeclara gratulationis* with an encyclical listing the innovations they charged against the Roman Church. Article XIII of that list is the Marian one, and its wording repays exact quotation:

**Patriarchal and Synodal Encyclical of Constantinople, 1895, art. XIII (English witness; not a Catholic act)**

“The one holy, catholic and apostolic Church of the seven Ecumenical Councils teaches that the supernatural incarnation of the only-begotten Son and Word of God, of the Holy Ghost and the Virgin Mary, is alone pure and immaculate; but the Papal Church scarcely forty years ago again made an innovation by laying down a novel dogma concerning the immaculate conception of the Mother of God and ever-Virgin Mary, which was unknown to the ancient Church (and strongly opposed at different times even by the more distinguished among the papal theologians).”<sup>91</sup>

Three things in that sentence deserve notice, because each is a precise datum rather than a general hostility. First, the objection is *historical*: the doctrine “was unknown to the ancient Church.” Second, it appeals to the Latin tradition’s own internal dissent—“strongly opposed at different times even by the more distinguished among the papal theologians,” which is the medieval debate of Chapter 5 turned into an ecumenical argument. Third, the same sentence that rejects the dogma calls Mary “the Mother of God and ever-Virgin”: the two ancient dogmas are affirmed in the act of denying the modern one.

Behind the historical objection lies a difference in the doctrine of original sin itself. The Greek tradition’s account of what is inherited from Adam—mortality and corruption, with sin as its consequence—does not pose the question to which “preserved from the stain of original sin at the first instant” is the answer, so that the definition can appear to Orthodox theologians both unnecessary and distorting. This reference states that difference at the level of a widely reported theological characterization and does not attempt to adjudicate it.<sup>92</sup> On the Assumption the disagreement

is of a different kind: the content—the Dormition and the glorification of the *Theotokos*—is held in the East’s liturgy, and *MD* itself quotes the Byzantine liturgy in evidence; what is rejected is the mode, a dogma defined by the Bishop of Rome alone.

## The Reformation traditions

The Reformers did not begin as Marian minimalists, and the sixteenth century’s confessional documents show it. The *Smalcald Articles* of 1537, Luther’s own, place among the articles “concerning which there is no contention or dispute, since we on both sides confess them” the statement that the Son “was conceived, without the cooperation of man, by the Holy Ghost, and was born of the pure, holy [and always] Virgin Mary.”<sup>93</sup> Both the divine motherhood (the article is a Christological one) and the perpetual virginity thus stand inside a foundational Lutheran confession, listed among the points not in dispute with Rome.

The objection that developed is structural rather than Marian, and it falls on the two modern definitions. It has two parts, and the Anglican–Roman Catholic International Commission states both with unusual clarity. The first is the sufficiency of Scripture, in the words of Article VI of the Thirty-Nine Articles, which ARCIC quotes: “Holy Scripture containeth all things necessary to salvation: so that whatsoever is not read therein, nor may be proved thereby, is not to be required of any man, that it should be believed as an article of the Faith.” The question this raises, as ARCIC puts it, is “whether these doctrines concerning Mary are revealed by God in a way which must be held by believers as a matter of faith.” The second is authority: the doctrines were defined by the Bishop of Rome “independent of a Council.”<sup>94</sup>

## ARCIC’s Seattle Statement (2005)

The most developed ecumenical treatment of the two modern dogmas is the Seattle Statement, and its structure is worth reporting exactly, because it is easy to over- or under-read.

What it agrees. On the Assumption, “given the understanding we have reached concerning the place of Mary in the economy of hope and grace, we can affirm together the teaching that God has taken the Blessed Virgin Mary in the fullness of her person into his glory as consonant with Scripture,” noting that the dogma “does not adopt a particular position as to how Mary’s life ended.” On the Immaculate Conception, “we can affirm together that Christ’s redeeming work reached ‘back’ in Mary to the depths of her being, and to her earliest beginnings.” Summing both: “the teaching about Mary in the two definitions of 1854 and 1950, understood within the biblical pattern of the economy of grace and hope outlined here, can be said to be consonant with the teaching of the Scriptures and the ancient common traditions.”<sup>95</sup>

What it does not resolve. “Consonant with Scripture” is not the same as “revealed by God and therefore *de fide*”; ARCIC says so, and leaves the question of required assent to a wider process of what it calls re-reception, adding that Anglicans have asked whether acceptance of the two definitions would be a condition of restored communion, and that “Roman Catholics find it hard to envisage a restoration of communion in which acceptance of certain doctrines would be requisite for some and not for others.”<sup>96</sup>

What it is. The document says so itself, in a paragraph headed “The Status of the Document”: it “is a joint statement of the Commission,” whose publication the appointing authorities “have allowed . . . so that it may be widely discussed,” and it “is not an authoritative declaration by the Roman Catholic Church or by the Anglican Communion, who will study and evaluate the document in due course.” This reference cites it accordingly: the most careful available statement of where the difficulty lies, published on the Holy See’s own Christian-unity site, carrying exactly the authority of a dialogue text and no more.<sup>97</sup>

## Where the disagreement actually lies

Gathering the evidence: the divine motherhood is not in dispute among the communions treated here; the perpetual virginity is confessed by the Orthodox and by the classical Lutheran confession, and is widely, though not universally, held in the wider Reformation inheritance today; the Immaculate Conception is rejected by the Ecumenical Patriarchate’s 1895 encyclical as an innovation and questioned by Anglicans as to its required assent; the Assumption’s content is largely shared and its definitional mode contested. The fault line, in short, is not Mariology but the

theology of development and the locus of teaching authority—which is why LG 67 warns preachers to “keep away from whatever, either by word or deed, could lead separated brethren or any other into error regarding the true doctrine of the Church,” and why the Church’s current discipline on Marian titles (Chapter 8) is framed with the same care.<sup>98</sup>

Currentness

The one mutable element in this reference is the Holy See’s present judgment on Marian cooperation titles. As of the verification date, the controlling document is the doctrinal note *Mater Populi Fidelis* of the Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith, approved by Pope Leo XIV on 7 October 2025 and published 4 November 2025, treated in Chapter 8. Its text, approval, publication date, and signatories were re-verified on the Holy See’s own page on the verification date, and a search for a later Holy See act on Marian titles returned none; a reader consulting this reference later should recheck, since silence is not evidence of continuance.<sup>99</sup>

10 Synopses of the Four Dogmas

Each synopsis condenses the corresponding chapter without erasing its historical difficulty; the chapter and its notes control. The fields are uniform so that the four can be compared field by field, and the last two fields—exclusions and the ecumenical position—are the ones a reader in a hurry is most likely to need.

| Synopsis — Divine Motherhood (Theotokos)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p><b>Object:</b> Mary is truly Mother of God: the Son born of her according to the flesh is the eternal Word in person.</p> <p><b>Mode and authority:</b> Conciliar dogma within Christology: Ephesus (431) approving Cyril’s second letter to Nestorius (DS 250–251); Chalcedon (451) Definition of Faith; Constantinople II (553) anathemas.</p> <p><b>Operative wording:</b> “... they ventured to call the Holy Virgin, the Mother of God ... because of her was born that holy body with a rational soul, to which the Word being personally united is said to be born according to the flesh” (Cyril, tr. Percival).</p> <p><b>Biblical center:</b> Lk 1:43 (“mother of my Lord”); Gal 4:4; Jn 1:14. Scripture supplies the reality, not the word.</p> <p><b>Principal early witnesses:</b> Ignatius (<i>Eph.</i> 7, 18–19: “both of Mary and of God”); Irenaeus’s Eve–Mary recapitulation (<i>AH</i> III.22.4); <i>Sub tuum praesidium</i> (dating disputed); Cyril’s letters; Formula of Reunion (433); Vincent of Lérins (c. 434).</p> <p><b>Thomistic support or limit:</b> Fully affirmed; classic locus ST III, q. 35 (motherhood terminates in the person), cited at that generality.</p> <p><b>Development hinge:</b> Nestorius’s <i>Christotokos</i> (428) forced the judgment that motherhood is of the person; the Formula of Reunion (433) settled the wording both parties could confess.</p> <p><b>Doctrinal fruit:</b> Guards the unity of Christ; ground of all Marian doctrine; source of the rule that every Marian dogma is first a Christological one.</p> <p><b>Required assent:</b> Divine and Catholic faith.</p> <p><b>Exclusions and open questions:</b> No origin of divinity in Mary; no divinization of her; the status of Cyril’s twelve anathemas and the procedural history of Ephesus remain complex and are not part of the defined object.</p> <p><b>Ecumenical position:</b> Common ground with the Orthodox and with the classical Reformation confessions; not in dispute among the communions surveyed in Chapter 9.</p> |

## Synopsis — Perpetual Virginity (Aeiparthenos)

**Object:** Mary virgin in conceiving, in giving birth, and ever after: *ante partum, in partu, post partum*.

**Mode and authority:** Ancient dogma of universal Tradition and the ordinary universal magisterium; creeds; Constantinople II (“ever-virgin,” DS 427); exact formulation at Lateran 649, canon 3 (DS 503), papally confirmed synod.

**Operative wording:** “... *semperque Virginem et immaculatam Mariam ... incorruptibiliter eum genuisse, indissolubili permanente et post partum eiusdem virginitate*” (DS 503).

**Biblical center:** Mt 1:18–25 and Lk 1:26–35 (virginal conception directly); the threefold confession received through Tradition.

**Principal early witnesses:** Creeds and Ignatius (virginal conception); *Protevangelium of James* as reception evidence; Jerome against Helvidius (383); Leo’s Tome (DS 291) on the incorrupt birth; *aeiparthenos* standard from the fifth century.

**Thomistic support or limit:** Fully affirmed: ST III, q. 28, a. 3 gives four reasons against Helvidius, all arguments of fittingness built on the received dogma.

**Development hinge:** Fourth-century controversy (Helvidius, Jovinian) and the conciliar fixing of *aeiparthenos*; canon 3 of 649 is collateral precision inside an anti-Monothelite confession.

**Doctrinal fruit:** Sign of God’s absolute initiative in the Incarnation and of Mary’s undivided self-gift; image of the Church’s undivided fidelity (LG 63–64).

**Required assent:** Divine and Catholic faith.

**Exclusions and open questions:** No anatomical theory defined; no contempt of marriage—and Jerome’s own invective against marriage is not the Church’s teaching; the “brothers” are identified as kinsmen, but the Hieronymian (cousins) and Epiphanian (prior marriage) readings both remain undefined.

**Ecumenical position:** Held by the Orthodox; confessed in the *Smalcald Articles* (1537) among articles then not in dispute; variously held in later Reformation practice.

## Synopsis — Immaculate Conception

**Object:** From the first instant of her conception Mary was preserved free from all stain of original sin, by singular grace, in view of Christ’s merits.

**Mode and authority:** Solemn *ex cathedra* definition: Pius IX, *Ineffabilis Deus*, 8 December 1854 (DS 2803–2804).

**Operative wording:** “*in primo instanti suae conceptionis ... intuitu meritorum Christi Jesu ... ab omni originalis culpae labe praeservatam immunem*” (DS 2803).

**Biblical center:** Gen 3:15 (the enmity, not the disputed pronoun) and Lk 1:28 (*kecharitomene*), read cumulatively within Tradition, not as isolated proofs.

**Principal early witnesses:** New Eve parallel (Justin, Irenaeus); *Panagia* praise; *immaculatam* at Lateran 649; the feast of the Conception, kept in some churches and tolerated at Rome in Thomas’s day.

**Thomistic support or limit:** Real limit: Thomas denied sanctification prior to animation to protect universal redemption (ST III, q. 27, a. 2), holding that she “did indeed contract original sin, but was cleansed therefrom before her birth”; the definition answers his concern through preservative redemption rather than overruling it.

**Development hinge:** Bernard’s objection (c. 1140), closing in submission to Rome; Scotus’s preservative-redemption argument (*Ordinatio* III, d. 3, q. 1); papal steering from Sixtus IV (1476–1483) through Trent (1546) to Alexander VII (1661), whose wording 1854 nearly reproduces.

**Doctrinal fruit:** Mary as the most perfect case of redemption; grace precedes all merit; the Church’s own destiny of holiness realized in one member.

**Required assent:** Divine and Catholic faith; formal sanction on willful denial.

**Exclusions and open questions:** Not the virginal conception of Jesus; personal sinlessness is a distinct teaching; no pre-Nicene witness states the formula, and the medieval difficulty is honest history; the 1858 Lourdes sentence is private revelation and adds nothing to the dogma.

**Ecumenical position:** Rejected as an innovation by the Ecumenical Patriarchate’s encyclical of 1895; ARCIC (2005) finds the teaching “consonant with” Scripture while leaving required assent unresolved.



## Synopsis — Assumption

**Object:** Mary, her earthly life completed, was assumed body and soul into heavenly glory.

**Mode and authority:** Solemn *ex cathedra* definition: Pius XII, *Munificentissimus Deus* §44, 1 November 1950 (DS 3903–3904), after the 1946 consultation of the episcopate.

**Operative wording:** “*Immaculatam Deiparam semper Virginem Mariam, expleto terrestres vitae cursu, fuisse corpore et anima ad caelestem gloriam assumptam*” (DS 3903).

**Biblical center:** No narrative text; canonical horizon: the Mother beside her Son’s lot (§38), new-Eve victory over sin and death (Gen 3:15 with 1 Cor 15, §39); Rev 12 and Ps 132 as reported figures.

**Principal early witnesses:** Dormition/Assumption liturgy East and West (Adrian I’s sacramentary, the Gallican books, the Byzantine office); eighth-century homilists, chiefly John Damascene; the *Transitus* apocrypha as reception only—and listed among rejected books in the *Decretum Gelasianum*; early centuries genuinely silent.

**Thomistic support or limit:** Occasional affirmations only; “never dealt directly with this question” (*MD* §31); no dedicated proof claimed—though Thomas himself argued from the Assumption when treating Mary’s sanctification.

**Development hinge:** Scholastic fittingness arguments; the petitions gathered from 1849 to 1940 and the almost two hundred Fathers of Vatican I; the 1946 consultation’s near-unanimity, read by *MD* §12 as itself an infallible manifestation.

**Doctrinal fruit:** Singular participation in the Resurrection; anticipation of the Church’s own end (CCC 966, 972–974); confirmation of the hope of bodily resurrection (*MD* §42).

**Required assent:** Divine and Catholic faith; formal sanction on willful denial.

**Exclusions and open questions:** Death versus dormition deliberately left open; no place, date, tomb, or *Transitus* narrative defined; assumption is God’s act, not an ascension.

**Ecumenical position:** Content largely shared with the Orthodox Dormition tradition, the mode of definition contested; ARCIC (2005) affirms the teaching as consonant with Scripture, noting the dogma takes no position on how Mary’s life ended.

## 11 Notes

1. *Dei Filius*, ch. 3 (DS 3011), checked in the English presentation of the First Vatican Council’s decrees at <https://www.papalencyclicals.net/councils/ecum20.htm>, 2026-07-25. All web loci cited in these notes were read on 2026-07-25 unless another date is stated; full bibliographic detail and witness identifications are in the References. Denzinger numbers are cited as DS in the revised numbering; where a claim depends on an online Denzinger witness, the References identify it.
2. The Latin of the Lateran and 1854 formulas is quoted from the online Latin Denzinger witness at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/enchiridion-symbolorum.html> (DS 503, 2803); the 1950 Latin from the Vatican Latin page of *Munificentissimus Deus*. The DS attribution of the Ephesine sentence follows CCC 495 n. 145. The table’s “level” column states the mode of the act, not a gradation of the truth believed: all four are believed with the same divine and Catholic faith.
3. Lk 1:28, Douay-Rheims (Challoner), read at <https://drbo.org/chapter/49001.htm>.
4. *Ineffabilis Deus*, section “The Annunciation,” English text read at <https://www.papalencyclicals.net/pius09/p9ineff.htm>; the constitution’s own footnote 22 cites Lk 1:28. The lexical description of *kecharitomene* given here is standard grammar, stated at that level; no critical-apparatus or lexicon collation is claimed, and no Greek text is reproduced in this reference (transliteration only). The Catechism’s own treatment is at CCC 490–491, 494, read at [https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/\\_P1K.HTM](https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/_P1K.HTM).
5. Gen 3:15, Douay-Rheims, read at <https://drbo.org/chapter/01003.htm>.
6. Douay-Rheims annotation at Gen 3:15, same locus. The annotation is a witness to the Catholic reading, not a text-critical determination; this reference makes no claim about the original reading beyond the divergence just stated.
7. *Ineffabilis Deus*, section “Interpreters of the Sacred Scripture,” same witness. The constitution proceeds from the enmity to the conclusion that Mary was “with him and through him, eternally at enmity with the evil serpent”—an argument from her association with the victor, not from the disputed pronoun.
8. *Munificentissimus Deus* §39, read at [https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/en/apost\\_constitutions/documents/hf\\_p-xii\\_apc\\_19501101\\_munificentissimus-deus.html](https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/en/apost_constitutions/documents/hf_p-xii_apc_19501101_munificentissimus-deus.html).

9. Apoc 12:1, Douay-Rheims, read at <https://drbo.org/chapter/73012.htm>.
10. MD §27, same witness. The paragraph goes on to note the same Doctors' use of Lk 1:28. This reference reproduces the constitution's own register: the scholastics' typology is reported as typology, and no exegetical result is claimed for it here.
11. Jn 2:1–5, Douay-Rheims, read at <https://drbo.org/chapter/50002.htm>. The Douay's own annotation at v. 4 observes that the words have been thought harsh by some commentators who did not consider v. 5. The register of the address (*gynai*, "Woman") is not rude in its idiom; this reference does not settle the disputed force of the reply, which is not a dogmatic question.
12. Jn 19:26–27, Douay-Rheims, read at <https://drbo.org/chapter/50019.htm>. The same verse 25 names "his mother's sister, Mary of Cleophas" among the women—the datum on which Jerome's reading of the "brothers of the Lord" turns (Chapter 4).
13. CCC 501, read at [https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/\\_P1K.HTM](https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/_P1K.HTM), quoting *Lumen gentium* 63; LG 58 checked at [https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist\\_councils/ii\\_vatican\\_council/documents/vat-ii\\_const\\_19641121\\_lumen-gentium\\_en.html](https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_const_19641121_lumen-gentium_en.html). Neither text makes the Cana or Cross scene a proof of a Marian dogma, and neither does this reference.
14. MD §38, same witness. The negative list here is a checked claim about the canonical text, not a concession that the doctrines are unfounded: their foundation is the deposit as a whole, transmitted in Scripture and Tradition, which is the Church's own account of how she knows them.
15. Council of Ephesus, extracts from the acts, in Henry R. Percival's translation, NPNF series 2, vol. 14 (New York, 1900), read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3810.htm>. The approval formally covered Cyril's letters read in session; the second letter (DS 250–251) is the one the later tradition treats as the council's doctrinal standard.
16. Cyril of Alexandria, second letter to Nestorius, tr. Percival, NPNF 2/14, read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3810.htm>. Percival renders the Greek *Theotokos* as "Mother of God" throughout. The letter's Greek text is the object approved; the English is a nineteenth-century translation witness.
17. Chalcedon, Definition of Faith, and Constantinople II, anathemas 2 and 6, tr. Percival, NPNF 2/14, read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3811.htm> and <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3812.htm>. The Catechism's apparatus cites the Ephesian sentence as DS 251 (CCC 495, note 145).
18. Ignatius, *Epistle to the Ephesians* 7, 18, 19, in the Ante-Nicene Fathers translation, read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0104.htm>. The New Advent page presents the shorter (Greek) recension; the Ignatian recension question is real and is not adjudicated here. Ignatius does not use *Theotokos*; he predicates of one subject both the divine title and the birth from Mary, which is the substance the later word defends.
19. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* III.22.4, ANF vol. 1 (Roberts–Rambaut, Buffalo, 1887; public domain), read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0103322.htm>. The parallel at V.19.1, read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0103519.htm>, adds the clause that "the Virgin Mary might become the patroness (*advocata*) of the virgin Eve"—a second-century use of *advocata* which this reference reports at its own date and does not convert into a warrant for later mediation language (Chapter 8).
20. Piotr Towarek, "Prayer 'Sub Tuum praesidium': Time of Origin, Place in Liturgy and Reception in Musical Culture. Outline of the Issues," *Vox Patrum* 80 (2021), pp. 239–268, DOI 10.31743/vp.12929, abstract read at <https://czasopisma.kul.pl/index.php/vp/article/view/12929>; the characterization of the recent palaeography (Förster, de Bruyn, Effenberger) is the article's. The Anglican–Roman Catholic International Commission cites the text with reference to O. Stegemüller's 1952 study and prints "a familiar English version": "We fly to thy protection, O holy Mother of God; despise not our petitions in our necessities but deliver us from all dangers, O ever glorious and blessed Virgin" (*Mary: Grace and Hope in Christ*, §9, read at <https://www.christianunity.va/content/unitacristiani/en/dialoghi/sezione-occidentale/comunione-anglicana/dialogo/arcic-ii/en.html>). That English is quoted strictly as ARCIC's witness to the text and is not offered as a devotional form; no critical edition or papyrus image was consulted, and this reference asserts no date.
21. Edgar C. S. Gibson's introduction to John Cassian in NPNF series 2, vol. 11 (public domain), read in the Christian Classics Ethereal Library text at <https://ccel.org/ccel/schaff/npnf211>. The Anastasius detail and the chronology of the appeal to Rome are reported on that nineteenth-century introduction's authority, not on primary documentation.
22. Same introduction, which dates the seven books to 430, before Ephesus, and credits Cassian with first connecting the new error to Pelagianism through the case of Leporius; it also judges the work hasty and less valuable than Cassian's earlier writings. Cassian is used here at reported level only: identity, occasion, and date from the NPNF introduction, with no passage quoted.
23. Twelve anathemas, tr. Percival, NPNF 2/14, read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3810.htm>; Percival prints the Greek *Theotokos* inside the first anathema and sets Nestorius's twelve counter-anathemas beside Cyril's. The bracketed scriptural tag is Percival's.

24. Percival's editorial bracket in the extracts from the acts, same page. The second letter, not the third with its anathemas, is what the tradition treats as the council's doctrinal standard, and this reference follows that usage; the anathemas are cited at their own level, as Cyril's document of 430.
25. Decree of the council against Nestorius, tr. Percival, same page. The procedural history of Ephesus—rival sessions, the Antiochene counter-synod, the imperial interventions—is complex and is not part of the defined object; this reference grounds the dogmatic claim in the received texts.
26. Cyril to John of Antioch (“Let the heavens rejoice”), with the Antiochene confession quoted verbatim inside it, tr. Percival, NPNF 2/14, read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3811.htm>, where the letter is printed among the Chalcedonian documents with the editor's note that it “is often styled the Ephesine Creed” and with references to Labbe and Cossart and to Migne, PG 77. The preceding sentence of the same confession professes Christ “perfect God, and perfect Man of a reasonable soul and flesh consisting . . . of the same substance with us according to his humanity.”
27. Vincent of Lérins, *Commonitory*, ch. XV, NPNF series 2, vol. 11 (public domain), read at <https://ccel.org/ccel/schaff/npnf211>. The same work's ch. XII describes Nestorius as bringing in “two sons of God, two Christs” and requiring *Christotokos* in place of *Theotokos*. Vincent's ch. XXIII rule of development—progress “in the same doctrine, in the same sense, and in the same meaning”—is the principle *Ineffabilis Deus* restates in 1854 (Chapter 5).
28. Lk 1:43 quoted from the Douay-Rheims (Challoner) translation, checked at <https://drbo.org/chapter/49001.htm>; Gal 4:4 and Jn 1:14 cited from the same version. The exegetical claim is limited to what the texts say: the one conceived and born of Mary is the Lord, God's own Son.
29. Cyril, third letter to Nestorius, tr. Percival, same page: “And since the holy Virgin brought forth corporally God made one with flesh according to nature, for this reason we also call her Mother of God, not as if the nature of the Word had the beginning of its existence from the flesh.”
30. CCC 495 with note 145, read at [https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/\\_P1K.HTM](https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/_P1K.HTM); the compact form at CCC 509: “Mary is truly ‘Mother of God’ since she is the mother of the eternal Son of God made man, who is God himself.”
31. LG 53, quoted in CCC 963, read at [https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/\\_P2C.HTM](https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/_P2C.HTM); *Lumen gentium* checked at [https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist\\_councils/ii\\_vatican\\_council/documents/vat-ii\\_const\\_19641121\\_lumen-gentium\\_en.html](https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_const_19641121_lumen-gentium_en.html).
32. Constantinople II, anathemas 2 and 6, tr. Percival, NPNF 2/14, read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3812.htm>. The Catechism's own note on the virginal motherhood cites the chain DS 291, 294, 427, 442, 503, 571, 1880 (CCC 499, note 154), placing Constantinople II (DS 427) and Lateran 649 (DS 503) inside the ordinary universal teaching.
33. DS 503 (older numbering 256), quoted from the Latin Enchiridion witness at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/enchiridion-symbolorum.html>. At “eum” that transcription prints “eam (eum?)”; the sense—that she incorruptibly bore him—is secured by the parallel English witness (Deferrari, DB 256) and by the canon's grammar, and the query mark is the transcription's, not the council's. In Deferrari's rendering the canon condemns whoever does not confess that Mary, “ever Virgin and immaculate,” conceived God the Word “of the Holy Spirit without seed” and bore him with “her virginity remaining indestructible even after His birth” (*The Sources of Catholic Dogma*, read at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/>).
34. Lateran Synod of 649, canons 1–4 (DS 500–504), Latin read at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/enchiridion-symbolorum.html>, whose heading dates the synod “5–31 octobre 649, sous saint Martin I.” The preceding entries in the same witness (DS 496–498) print the defense of Honorius's letters offered by Pope John IV, which locates the synod inside the Monothelite crisis. Martin I's subsequent arrest, trial at Constantinople, and exile are standard history and are not documented here.
35. Leo the Great, *Tome* (Ep. 28 to Flavian), ch. 2, DS 291: “Conceptus quippe est de Spiritu Sancto intra uterum virginis matris, quae illum ita salva virginitate edidit, quemadmodum salva virginitate concepit,” read in the Latin witness at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/enchiridion-symbolorum.html>. The English in the text is this reference's rendering of the Latin clause and is presented as commentary, not as a translation witness. The identification of DS 291 with the Tome rests on the witness's own sequence and chapter marks (“c. 3,” “c. 4” at DS 293–294).
36. Douay-Rheims (Challoner), checked at <https://drbo.org/chapter/49001.htm>. CCC 496–498 states the Church's confession of the virginal conception and its early credal attestation.
37. CCC 500 with notes, read at [https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/\\_P1K.HTM](https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/_P1K.HTM). The linguistic claims are stated at the level the evidence supports: these texts do not prove other children, and the Church's reading is ancient; the texts alone, without Tradition, would leave the question verbally open.
38. Jerome, *The Perpetual Virginity of Blessed Mary* §6, NPNF series 2, vol. 6 (public domain), read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3007.htm>. Section numbers follow that translation. The argument establishes that Mt 1:25 does not entail subsequent relations; Jerome does not claim it excludes them, and neither does this reference.

39. Same witness, §12, quoting Num 18:15–16 and Lk 2:22–24. Jerome’s conclusion: “first-born is a title of him who opens the womb, and is not to be restricted to him who has brothers.”
40. Same witness, §§15–17. The identification requires reading “Mary of Clopas” as the sister (or kinswoman) of the Lord’s mother and as the wife of Alphaeus, a chain Jerome argues at §15 and which is not defined doctrine.
41. Same witness, §21, which also states Jerome’s methodological rule: “as we do not deny what is written, so we do reject what is not written . . . That Mary was married after she brought forth, we do not believe, because we do not read it.”
42. Same witness, §19. Jerome’s list is a claim about those writers’ views, not a set of citations; this reference reports it as Jerome’s claim. Helvidius had adduced Tertullian and Victorinus of Pettau; Jerome concedes Victorinus and dismisses Tertullian on ecclesial grounds.
43. CCC 500, same locus. The Catechism states the conclusion (not other children of Mary) and the Old Testament usage, without adjudicating between the cousins and the prior-marriage readings—the exact restraint this reference imitates.
44. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 28, a. 3 corpus (Dominican Fathers translation, 1920; public domain), read at <https://www.newadvent.org/summa/4028.htm>. The same question holds the virginity in conceiving (a. 1) and in the birth (a. 2) and treats her vow of virginity (a. 4). Thomas’s reasons are arguments of fittingness built on the dogma, not proofs of it.
45. DS 1880, Latin read at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/enchiridion-symbolorum.html>, which dates the constitution 7 August 1555; the same witness’s running heading prints “Pie IV,” an evident slip for Paul IV, and the discrepancy is disclosed here rather than silently corrected. The English clauses are this reference’s rendering of the Latin and are commentary, not a translation witness.
46. LG 57, checked at the Vatican English text of *Lumen gentium*; CCC 499, read at [https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/\\_P1K.HTM](https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/_P1K.HTM). Augustine’s summary is quoted at CCC 510: “a virgin in conceiving her Son, a virgin in giving birth to him, a virgin in carrying him, a virgin in nursing him at her breast, always a virgin.”
47. DS 852 (Lyons II, Session IV, 6 July 1274, profession of Michael Palaeologus): “temporaliter natum de Spiritu Sancto et Maria semper Virgine”; DS 1337 (Florence, decree for the Jacobites, 1442): “ex immaculato utero Mariae Virginis”; both read in the Latin witness at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/enchiridion-symbolorum.html>. The English clauses are this reference’s renderings and are commentary. Note that Florence’s *immaculato* qualifies the womb in a Christological sentence and is not a statement of the 1854 dogma.
48. *Ineffabilis Deus*, English text read at <https://www.papalencyclicals.net/pius09/p9ineff.htm> (translator unidentified on the witness; the same English circulates at EWTN and the New Advent library). The Vatican web page for the constitution presents only a title shell without body text in English, a checked negative result. Latin, DS 2803: “declaramus, pronuntiamus et definimus doctrinam, quae tenet, beatissimam Virginem Mariam in primo instanti suae conceptionis fuisse singulari omnipotentis Dei gratia et privilegio, intuitu meritorum Christi Jesu Salvatoris humani generis, ab omni originalis culpa labe praeservatam immunem, esse a Deo revelatam atque idcirco ab omnibus fidelibus firmiter constanterque credendam,” checked at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/enchiridion-symbolorum.html>; the constitution’s own footnote 29 prints the same Latin.
49. Same witness, immediately after the definition. The definition was made by Pius IX’s own supreme apostolic authority after consulting the episcopate (the 1849 encyclical *Ubi primum* solicited the bishops’ judgment, an act the constitution itself recounts); it is the classic instance of the *ex cathedra* mode that Vatican I would define in *Pastor aeternus* (1870), sixteen years later. The final clause is worth noting for its restraint: the outward penalties attach to outward expression, not to the interior thought the sentence deplores.
50. CCC 490–493, read at [https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/\\_P1K.HTM](https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/_P1K.HTM); CCC 491 quotes the definition, citing DS 2803. *Lumen gentium* 56 supplies the conciliar synthesis quoted in CCC 492: she is “redeemed, in a more exalted fashion, by reason of the merits of her Son.”
51. Gen 3:15 quoted from the Douay-Rheims, whose own annotation records the divergent readings, checked at <https://drbo.org/chapter/01003.htm>; the constitution’s use of the verse read at the *Ineffabilis Deus* witness above, section “Interpreters of the Sacred Scripture.”
52. Lk 1:28, Douay-Rheims, checked at <https://drbo.org/chapter/49001.htm>. The lexical claim—perfect passive participle of *charitoo*—is standard grammar; the inferential distance from greeting to dogma is stated in Chapter 2, not concealed.
53. CCC 491–494, which reads the development as the Church becoming “ever more aware” of what grace had done; the New Eve and *Panagia* witnesses are cited at CCC 493–494 generality. Augustine, *On Nature and Grace* 36.42, is characterized here from its accepted scope—exemption from the discussion of personal sin—and is not claimed as an Immaculate-Conception statement; the constitution’s footnote 24 cites the same chapter.
54. Bernard of Clairvaux, letter to the canons of Lyons on the Conception of S. Mary (c. 1140), §§2, 4–6, 8, in Samuel J. Eales’s translation from Mabillon, *Some Letters of Saint Bernard, Abbot of Clairvaux* (London: John Hodges, 1904; public

- domain), read in the Christian Classics Ethereal Library text at <https://ccel.org/ccel/bernard/letters>, where the letter is numbered XLV; it is commonly cited elsewhere as Ep. 174. The letter also dismisses a purported revelation adduced for the feast (the editor's note ascribes it to an English abbot named Elsin). No collation against the Latin critical edition was performed.
55. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 27, a. 1 corpus, Dominican Fathers translation, read at <https://www.newadvent.org/summa/4027.htm>. The same corpus argues by analogy from a tractate on the Assumption of the Virgin which Thomas ascribes to Augustine; the ascription is Thomas's and is not verified here—a datum with its own interest, since it shows a thirteenth-century Doctor treating the Assumption as the securer of the two beliefs.
  56. *ST* III, q. 27, a. 2 corpus and ad 2, same witness. The article's conclusion in its plainest form: “the Blessed Virgin did indeed contract original sin, but was cleansed therefrom before her birth from the womb.” Thomas did not teach the 1854 formula; the definition answers his stated concern rather than overruling it, and the profile governing this reference requires that difficulty to be stated rather than softened.
  57. Same article, ad 3. Thomas's further reason for holding that she contracted original sin is that she “was conceived by way of fleshly concupiscence,” quoting Augustine, *De nuptiis et concupiscentia* (ad 4)—the premise the later tradition, following Scotus, does not need.
  58. John Duns Scotus, *Ordinatio* III, d. 3, q. 1, cited by standard reference; no critical-edition collation is claimed and no sentence of Scotus is quoted here. The definition's own clause *intuitu meritorum Christi Jesu* enacts the Scotist resolution without naming him—a checked absence: the constitution's text does not contain the words “Scotus” or “Scotist.”
  59. *Ineffabilis Deus*, section “Testimonies of the Catholic World,” same witness. Specific academic acts frequently reported in the literature—for example a requirement at the University of Paris that graduands defend the doctrine—were not verified at this project's ceilings and are therefore not asserted here; the constitution's generic sentence is the level of the claim made.
  60. DS 1400 and 1425–1426, Latin read at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/enchiridion-symbolorum.html>. The dating of *Cum praeexelsa* illustrates why a reference should print its witnesses: *Ineffabilis Deus*'s footnotes 4 and 8 date it 28 February 1476, while the Denzinger witness heads it “27 février 1477” with the parenthesis (“1476” st. cur.)—that is, 1476 by the curial style, in which the year began at the Incarnation. The two datings are the same act, and neither witness is in error.
  61. Trent, Session V, can. 6 (DS 1516), Latin read at the same Denzinger witness; the English is this reference's rendering of the Latin and is commentary. *Ineffabilis Deus* recounts the same act in its section “The Council of Trent,” with the Latin in footnote 12. The declaration is precisely a non-inclusion, not a definition—and the constitution reads it as evidence that the Fathers of Trent judged that nothing in Scripture, Tradition, or the Fathers stood against the doctrine.
  62. DS 2015–2017, Latin read at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/enchiridion-symbolorum.html>, whose heading dates the brief 8 December 1661: “eius animam in primo instanti creationis atque infusionis in corpus fuisse speciali Dei gratia et privilegio, intuitu meritorum Iesu Christi eius filii, humani generis Redemptoris, a macula peccati originalis praeservatam immunem.” The English here follows the constitution's own translation of the same sentence at its section “The Roman Doctrine.” Comparison with DS 2803 shows how much of the 1854 formula was already fixed in 1661: what 1854 adds is not the content but the act.
  63. *Ineffabilis Deus*, section “The Mind of the Bishops,” same witness, which dates the encyclical 2 February 1849 and recounts the special congregation of cardinals and theologians and the consistory that preceded the act. The consultation's numerical results are not given in the constitution and are not asserted here.
  64. *Ineffabilis Deus*, section “Testimonies of Tradition,” same witness; compare Vincent of Lérins, *Commonitory* ch. XXIII: progress “in the same doctrine, in the same sense, and in the same meaning” (NPNF 2/11, read at <https://ccel.org/ccel/schaff/npnf211>). The parallel is stated as a parallel; the constitution does not name Vincent at this point in the English witness.
  65. The Lourdes events, their witnesses, the exact Gascon wording and its transmission, and the 1862 episcopal judgment are treated in the companion Claude study *Lourdes* in this same series, which holds the primary and custodial records; nothing in the present chapter depends on them. On the general principle, see CCC 66–67: public revelation is complete in Christ, and no private revelation can complete or correct it.
  66. *Munificentissimus Deus* §44, English read at [https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/en/apost\\_constitutions/documents/hf\\_p-xii\\_apc\\_19501101\\_munificentissimus-deus.html](https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/en/apost_constitutions/documents/hf_p-xii_apc_19501101_munificentissimus-deus.html); Latin (AAS 42 [1950] 753–771) at the parallel Vatican Latin page: “pronuntiamus, declaramus et definimus divinitus revelatum dogma esse: Immaculatam Deiparam semper Virginem Mariam, expleto terrestri vitae cursu, fuisse corpore et anima ad caelestem gloriam assumptam.” Paragraph numbers follow the Vatican English presentation (48 paragraphs).
  67. Same witness, §45; §47 adds the ordinary prohibition of altering or opposing the act.

68. Same witness, §§4–5, 41. The inference from the Immaculate Conception to incorruption is the constitution’s own theological argument, not a further definition; §5 states it as God’s willing an exemption from the general rule, not as a necessity binding God.
69. Pius XII, *Deiparae Virginis Mariae* (1 May 1946), §§2, 4, read at [https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/en/encyclicals/documents/hf\\_p-xii\\_enc\\_01051946\\_deiparae-virginis-mariae.html](https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/en/encyclicals/documents/hf_p-xii_enc_01051946_deiparae-virginis-mariae.html). The same Vatican page’s editorial note records that the letter went out *in forma del tutto riservata*, was first printed in *Il Monitore Ecclesiastico* (1946), and was published as an encyclical in the *Acta Apostolicae Sedis* only in 1950—a publication history worth recording, because it means the consultation was conducted privately and promulgated retrospectively. *MD* §11 quotes the two questions in slightly different English.
70. Same witness, §12, which then quotes Vatican I twice: the Holy Spirit was promised the successors of Peter “not . . . that, by his revelation, they might manifest new doctrine, but so that, by his assistance, they might guard . . . the deposit of faith”; and the *Dei Filius* criterion of what must be believed by divine and Catholic faith. The numerical result of the consultation is not published in the constitution and is not asserted here.
71. The apocryphal narratives are collected in translation among the Ante-Nicene Fathers under the heading “Apocryphal Works on the Assumption of Mary,” read at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0832.htm>, which prints “The Account of St. John the Theologian of the Falling Asleep of the Holy Mother of God” together with Latin narratives. Their date, dependence, and original language are contested in the scholarly literature and are not settled here; no reconstruction of a lost early source is offered.
72. *Decretum Gelasianum de libris recipiendis et non recipiendis*, part V, in the English translation of Ernst von Dobschütz’s edition (Texte und Untersuchungen 38.4, 1912) at [https://www.tertullian.org/decretum\\_eng.htm](https://www.tertullian.org/decretum_eng.htm), where the entry reads “the book which is called the Assumption of holy Mary *apocryphus*.” The decree’s own date and authorship (Damasus, Gelasius, or a sixth-century compiler) are disputed; the Denzinger witness at DS 350–354 prints the list of received books but abbreviates the apocrypha as “a long series” without naming them, which is why the fuller edition is cited here.
73. String searches for “Transitus” and “apocry” over the full retrieved English text of *MD* return no occurrences. The constitution’s own account of why it argues from worship is at §20: “the liturgy of the Church does not engender the Catholic faith, but rather springs from it,” so the Fathers and Doctors preaching on the feast “did not draw their teaching from the feast itself as from a primary source, but rather they spoke of this doctrine as something already known and accepted.”
74. *MD* §§17–18, same witness, with the constitution’s own footnotes 11–12 identifying the liturgical sources. The Roman prayer’s phrase “suffered temporal death” (*mortem subiit temporalem* in the constitution’s source) is significant for the death question below: the Roman liturgy the constitution cites presumes her death.
75. Same witness, §19. These are the constitution’s historical claims about earlier papal acts, reported on its authority as witness to its own cited sources and not re-verified in the liturgical archives.
76. Same witness, §21, quoting John Damascene as the constitution quotes him. §22 reports that “statements no less clear and accurate” occur in sermons of Fathers of the same or earlier periods—a generality this reference does not extend into a claim of early unanimity.
77. *MD* §§28–35, same witness. Suarez’s methodological norm, quoted at §37, states the register plainly: “keeping in mind the standards of propriety, and when there is no contradiction or repugnance on the part of Scripture, the mysteries of grace which God has wrought in the Virgin” are to be measured by what befits her dignity.
78. *MD* §31; *ST* III, q. 27, a. 1 corpus, read at <https://www.newadvent.org/summa/4027.htm>. The ascription of the Assumption tractate to Augustine is Thomas’s and is not verified here; the point made is about Thomas’s argumentative practice, not about the tractate’s authorship.
79. Same witness, §§26–27, 38–39. Revelation 12’s woman retains her Israel–Church–Mary polyvalence; the constitution reports the scholastics reading the Assumption as “signified” there, a typological claim.
80. Same witness, §§14, 17, 21, 44. The open character of the death question is stated from the definition’s own wording, against the background of a constitution whose own sources presume the death—the combination that makes the omission deliberate rather than accidental.
81. CCC 966, 972–974, read at [https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/\\_P2C.HTM](https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/_P2C.HTM); LG 59 checked at the Vatican English text: “the Immaculate Virgin, preserved free from all guilt of original sin, on the completion of her earthly sojourn, was taken up body and soul into heavenly glory, and exalted by the Lord as Queen of the universe.” The Queenship named there is authoritative teaching consequent on the Assumption, not a further dogma. The closing sentence is *MD* §42.
82. *Lumen gentium* 54 and 67, Vatican English text read at [https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist\\_councils/ii\\_vatican\\_council/documents/vat-ii\\_const\\_19641121\\_lumen-gentium\\_en.html](https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_const_19641121_lumen-gentium_en.html). LG 67 adds that true devotion “consists neither in sterile or transitory affection, nor in a certain vain credulity, but proceeds from true faith, by which we are led to know

the excellence of the Mother of God, and we are moved to a filial love toward our mother and to the imitation of her virtues.” LG 54 also states what the Council did *not* intend: not “a complete doctrine on Mary,” and not a decision of “those questions which the work of theologians has not yet fully clarified.”

83. *Ineffabilis Deus*, section headed “Supreme Reason for the Privilege: The Divine Maternity,” read at <https://www.palencyclicals.net/pius09/p9ineff.htm>. The fittingness argument is the constitution’s; it is reported here as the constitution’s reasoning, not offered as a demonstration.
84. LG 63–64, Vatican English text, same locus. The Ambrosian attribution is the Council’s own (its note 18\*). The two titles—mother and virgin—are precisely the two ancient Marian dogmas, now predicated analogically of the Church.
85. LG 65 and 68, same locus; the Vatican English of LG 68 prints “is the world to come” where the sense requires “in,” and the quotation is reproduced here as the official English page prints it. CCC 972 gathers the same teaching: in Mary the Church “contemplates what she herself is and what she is to become.”
86. The incorporation of the Marian schema into *Lumen gentium* as its eighth chapter, rather than a separate conciliar document, is visible in the constitution’s own structure (ch. VIII, §§52–69) and its opening statement of intention at LG 54. This reference reports the structural fact and its doctrinal significance; the conciliar debate that produced the decision is not documented here.
87. CCC 493, 963–975, read at the Vatican IntraText pages cited above; LG 59 at the Vatican English text of *Lumen gentium*.
88. LG 60–62, checked at the Vatican English text; CCC 968–970 quotes the same passages.
89. *Mater Populi Fidelis*, §§22, 27, 67, 69, read at [https://www.vatican.va/roman\\_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc\\_ddd\\_doc\\_20251104\\_mater-populi-fidelis\\_en.html](https://www.vatican.va/roman_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc_ddd_doc_20251104_mater-populi-fidelis_en.html). Historical papal uses of “Co-redemptrix” (reviewed at §18) retain their own dates and authority; the note governs present constructive use. The note is a papally approved doctrinal note, not a solemn definition; it is the current controlling statement on these titles.
90. LG 69, Vatican English text read at [https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist\\_councils/ii\\_vatican\\_council/documents/vat-ii\\_const\\_19641121\\_lumen-gentium\\_en.html](https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_const_19641121_lumen-gentium_en.html).
91. Patriarchal Encyclical of 1895, art. XIII, English text read at [http://orthodoxinfo.com/ecumenism/encyc\\_1895.aspx](http://orthodoxinfo.com/ecumenism/encyc_1895.aspx). The witness is a private Orthodox website reproducing a nineteenth-century English translation; neither the translator nor the underlying Greek edition is identified on the page, and no collation was performed. The document is the synodal reply of Anthimus VII to Leo XIII’s *Praeclara gratulationis* (1894); an earlier article of the same encyclical also lists “the immaculate conception of the ever-Virgin” among the points the Latins would have to prove from the Fathers and the councils.
92. Reported at that level: no Orthodox conciliar or synodal act defining the doctrine of ancestral sin was identified and read for this publication, and the characterization is therefore not attributed to any particular authority. What is documented above is the 1895 synodal encyclical’s own reasoning.
93. *The Smalcald Articles* (1537), Part I, art. IV, in the translation of F. Bente and W. H. T. Dau, *Triglot Concordia: The Symbolical Books of the Ev. Lutheran Church* (St. Louis: Concordia, 1921), pp. 453–529; public-domain text read at <https://www.gutenberg.org/files/273/273-h/273-h.htm>. The square brackets are the Triglot’s own editorial convention marking wording carried by one of the parallel originals; that convention, not this reference, governs the bracketed words, and no claim about the German and Latin recensions is made here beyond what the edition prints.
94. *Mary: Grace and Hope in Christ* (the Seattle Statement of ARCIC II, agreed 2004, published 2005), §§60, 62, read at <https://www.christianunity.va/content/unitacristiani/en/dialoghi/sezione-occidentale/comunione-anglicana/dialogo/arcic-ii/en.html>.
95. Same witness, §§58–60. The statement adds, of the Immaculate Conception, an observation that is doctrinally acute: “the negative notion of ‘sinlessness’ runs the risk of obscuring the fullness of Christ’s saving work. It is not so much that Mary lacks something which other human beings ‘have’, namely sin, but that the glorious grace of God filled her life from the beginning.”
96. Same witness, §§60–63. §61 also observes that the 1854 and 1950 phrases “revealed by God” and “divinely revealed” reflect the theology of revelation dominant when they were made and are to be understood in the light of *Dei verbum*—an interpretative move which is the Commission’s, not a magisterial act.
97. Same witness, “The Status of the Document,” preceding the statement; the co-chairmen’s preface is signed by Alexander J. Brunett and Peter F. Carnley at Seattle on the Feast of the Presentation, 2 February 2004. The Commission’s own §63 makes any “re-reception” conditional on “a mutual re-reception of an effective teaching authority in the Church.”
98. LG 67, Vatican English text, same locus. The characterization of present Reformation practice is a general observation, not a documented survey, and is offered at that level.

99. *Mater Populi Fidelis*, re-read 2026-07-25 at [https://www.vatican.va/roman\\_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc\\_ddf\\_doc\\_20251104\\_mater-populi-fidelis\\_en.html](https://www.vatican.va/roman_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc_ddf_doc_20251104_mater-populi-fidelis_en.html) (approval by Leo XIV, 7 October 2025; publication 4 November 2025; signed by Cardinal Víctor Manuel Fernández, Prefect, and Mons. Armando Matteo, Secretary for the Doctrinal Section). The negative currentness check was a web search for later Holy See acts on Marian titles, which returned only the 2025 note and coverage of it; the Vatican Press Office bulletin of 4 November 2025 announces the same document. The Dicastery’s general document index page returned an empty body on the verification date—a checked negative that limits the strength of the search, and is recorded rather than concealed. The four dogmas themselves are stable doctrine and are not given artificial currentness.

## A Scope, Status, and Qualifications

### Question and thesis boundary

This reference answers one question: what exactly the Catholic Church has defined in the four commonly identified Marian dogmas—divine motherhood, perpetual virginity, Immaculate Conception, and bodily Assumption—with each definition’s text, authority, history, biblical and patristic roots, exclusions, and current catechetical framing; how the four cohere as one economy; where other Christian communions agree and disagree; and with the boundary between these dogmas and other Marian teaching kept explicit. It is a source-audited Catholic study instrument: not a critical edition, a magisterial act, a devotional manual, or an apparition study, and it proposes no new definition.

### Corpus and exclusions

Included: the four dogmas; the defining or formulating acts (Ephesus 431 with Cyril’s second letter; Chalcedon 451 and Constantinople II 553 in reception; Lateran 649 canon 3; *Ineffabilis Deus* 1854; *Munificentissimus Deus* 1950, with *Deiparae Virginis Mariae* 1946); the patristic and scholastic witnesses named in the References (Ignatius, Irenaeus, Jerome, Leo’s Tome, Vincent of Lérins, Bernard, Thomas); the papal and conciliar acts of the Immaculate-Conception controversy from Sixtus IV to Alexander VII; the catechetical loci CCC 484–511 and 963–975 and *Lumen gentium* ch. 8; the identified non-Catholic documents used in Chapter 9 (the 1895 Constantinopolitan encyclical, the *Smalcald Articles*, the ARCIC Seattle Statement); and the current DDF judgment on cooperation titles (*Mater Populi Fidelis*, 2025). Excluded: Marian feasts, prayers, devotions, iconography, and apparitions as such—the Lourdes events are mentioned once, and only to place them outside the dogma; critical-text questions in the conciliar acts; the internal history of the *Transitus* literature; the conciliar debates behind *Lumen gentium* ch. 8; and every question the Church has left open, which is reported as open rather than settled.

### Chronological range and currentness

Subject range: from the New Testament to the DDF note of 4 November 2025. Online verification date: sources were checked 2026-07-25; stable ancient doctrine is not given artificial currentness, and the one mutable judgment used (on Marian titles) was re-verified in the official 2025 English text on that date, together with a negative search for any later Holy See act on the same subject.

### Taxonomy and terminology

The reference distinguishes throughout: *dogma* (revealed truth proposed as such, owed divine and Catholic faith); *authoritative doctrine* (for example Mary’s personal sinlessness, Queenship, Mother of the Church); *conciliar synthesis* (*Lumen gentium*’s ordering of cooperation language and its Mary–Church typology); *administrative doctrinal judgment* (the 2025 note’s rule on titles); *theological opinion* (death versus dormition; cousins versus prior-marriage kinsmen); *typology* (Rev 12, Ps 132, new Eve as figure); *apocryphal reception* (*Protevangelium*, *Transitus*); *devotional witness* (*Sub tuum praesidium*); and *ecumenical dialogue text* (ARCIC), which is not an act of either communion’s magisterium. Transliterations (*Theotokos*, *aeiparthenos*, *kecharitomene*, *Panagia*, *Koimesis*) stand for Greek originals not reproduced here; no Greek script is set in this publication.



## Source hierarchy and method

Priority: defined texts in identified witnesses; then conciliar and papal acts; then the Catechism and *Lumen gentium* as current framing; then patristic and scholastic witnesses at their own dates; then scholarship; then documents of other communions, cited as their own communions’ acts and never as Catholic authority. Definition texts are quoted exactly from the witnesses named in the Notes and References; historical claims inside the two papal constitutions are reported on the constitutions’ authority as witnesses to their cited acts, not re-verified in the primary archives. Latin is quoted where the defining wording matters; no project or AI translation is offered as source text—English renderings of defined formulas come only from the identified translation witnesses, and where this reference renders a Latin clause itself (Leo’s Tome at DS 291, Trent at DS 1516, Paul IV at DS 1880, the Lyons and Florence professions) the rendering is marked in its note as commentary rather than as a translation witness.

## Qualifications and unresolved items

(1) The English of *Ineffabilis Deus* used here has no identified translator; its wording is the common web text, quoted with that caution, and the Vatican English page is a checked title-only shell. (2) The online Latin Denzinger witness does not identify its print edition; its readings were corroborated against parallel witnesses where quoted; its query mark at DS 503, its stray period at DS 2803, and its running heading “Pie IV” at DS 1880 are disclosed at the points of use. (3) Percival’s 1900 translations are dated though public domain; no collation against modern critical editions (Schwartz, Riedinger, Tanner) was performed, and the same holds for the NPNF 2/6 Jerome, the NPNF 2/11 Vincent of Lérins, the ANF Ignatius and Irenaeus, and Eales’s 1904 Bernard. (4) The Ignatian recension question, the date and dependence of the *Transitus* literature, the date and authorship of the *Decretum Gelasianum*, and the palaeographic date of P. Ryl. III 470 are all live scholarly disputes; each is reported as disputed and none is adjudicated. (5) Scotus’s *Ordinatio* III, d. 3, q. 1 is cited by standard reference without critical-edition collation, and *potuit, decuit, fecit* is not attributed to him verbatim. (6) Specific academic acts often reported in the Immaculate-Conception literature (for example a Paris faculty requirement of 1497) were not verified and are not asserted. (7) The characterization of the Greek doctrine of ancestral sin in Chapter 9 is reported at the level of a widely held theological description, with no Orthodox synodal act read for it; the 1895 encyclical is quoted from a private site’s unattributed English translation, uncollated against the Greek. (8) DS numbers follow the revised numbering as used by the Catechism’s apparatus; where only the older numbering could be checked online, both are recorded in the research records. (9) The identification of DS 291 with Leo’s Tome, and of the CCC 499 chain’s remaining members, rests on the online witness’s own sequence and headings rather than on a critical edition. (10) No independent Mariological, patristic, conciliar-historical, medieval, textual-critical, or ecclesiastical review has occurred, and no ecclesiastical approval is claimed or implied.

## Rights

Project prose is original and intended for CC BY 4.0. Quotations remain under their own status: Percival (1900), the NPNF 2/6 and 2/11 translations, the Ante-Nicene Fathers (1885–1887), Eales’s Bernard (1904), the Bente–Dau *Triglott Concordia* (1921), the Dominican Fathers’ *Summa* (1920), the Douay-Rheims, and the underlying Latin acts are public domain; Vatican web texts (CCC, *Lumen gentium*, *Munificentissimus Deus*, *Deiparae Virginis Mariae*, *Mater Populi Fidelis*, the ARCIC Seattle Statement as published on the Holy See’s Christian-unity site) and the unattributed *Ineffabilis Deus* English are quoted within ordinary scholarly limits with citation; Deferrari’s Denzinger is used in short attributed clauses only; the 1895 encyclical’s English and the von Dobschütz-based translation of the *Decretum Gelasianum* are quoted in short attributed extracts. Online availability is not treated as a reuse license.

## B References

Witnesses are listed with role and rights notes; access date for all web loci is 2026-07-25 unless stated. Stable source identities for the starred entries are registered in the repository source library; this publication’s bindings are in `research/source-bindings.toml`.

## Defining and formulating acts

- \*Council of Ephesus (431), extracts from the acts with Cyril's second letter to Nestorius, the third letter with the twelve anathemas and Nestorius's counter-anathemas, and the decree of deposition; the Formula of Reunion in Cyril's letter to John of Antioch (433) among the Chalcedonian documents; Chalcedon (451) and Constantinople II (553), in *The Seven Ecumenical Councils*, tr. Henry R. Percival, NPNF series 2, vol. 14 (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1900; public domain), New Advent transcriptions: <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3810.htm>, <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3811.htm>, <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3812.htm>. Role: definition-text and reception witness (divine motherhood; *aeiparthenos*), with the editor's bracketed note on the lacuna at the anathemas disclosed in the Notes.
- \*Lateran Council of 649, canons 1–4 (DS 500–504, with canon 3 = DS 503 / DB 256), Latin with dual numbering at <http://patristica.net/denzinger/enchiridion-symbolorum.html>; English clauses from Roy J. Deferrari, *The Sources of Catholic Dogma* (St. Louis: Herder, 1957; rights unresolved, quoted in short attributed clauses), <http://patristica.net/denzinger/>. Role: formulation witness (perpetual virginity) and its Monothelite context (the same witness's DS 496–498). The underlying seventh-century Latin is public domain; the online Latin witness does not identify its print edition and its query mark at DS 503 is disclosed in the Notes.
- \*Denzinger, *Enchiridion symbolorum*, further loci in the same Latin witness: DS 291 (Leo's Tome, virginity preserved in conceiving and bearing), 852 (Lyons II, 1274), 1337 (Florence, 1442), 1400 and 1425–1426 (Sixtus IV, *Cum praeexcelsa* and *Grave nimis*), 1516 (Trent, Session V, can. 6), 1880 (Paul IV, *Cum quorundam hominum*, 1555), 2015–2017 (Alexander VII, *Sollicitudo omnium ecclesiarum*, 8 December 1661), 2803–2804 (the 1854 definition and sanction). Role: Latin textual control. The witness's date for *Cum praeexcelsa* (27 February 1477, “1476 st. cur.”) and its running heading “Pie IV” at DS 1880 are recorded as found.
- \*Pius IX, *Ineffabilis Deus* (8 December 1854; DS 2803–2804), English (translator unidentified on the witness) at <https://www.papalencyclicals.net/pius09/p9ineff.htm>. Role: definition text; the constitution's own argument structure (liturgical argument, Roman doctrine, papal sanctions, Trent, testimonies of Tradition, interpreters of Scripture, the Annunciation, Eve, biblical figures, the mind of the bishops, the definition); and its historical survey (Trent Sess. V, Sixtus IV, Alexander VII 1661, *Ubi primum* of 2 February 1849), with its Latin footnotes. Checked negative: the Vatican web English page (<https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-ix/en/documents/18541208-costituzione-apostolica-ineffabilis-deus.html>) delivers a title shell without body text; the Latin original is public domain.
- \*Pius XII, *Munificentissimus Deus* (1 November 1950; AAS 42 [1950] 753–771; DS 3903–3904), Vatican English (48 numbered paragraphs) and Latin web texts: [https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/en/apost\\_constitutions/documents/hf\\_p-xii\\_apc\\_19501101\\_munificentissimus-deus.html](https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/en/apost_constitutions/documents/hf_p-xii_apc_19501101_munificentissimus-deus.html) and the parallel /la/ page. Role: definition text (§44), sanction (§45), the bond with 1854 (§§4–5), consultation record (§§11–12), liturgical argument (§§17–20), Damascene (§21), scholastic survey (§§24–37), scriptural foundation (§§38–39), and definition rationale (§§40–42).
- \*Pius XII, *Deiparae Virginis Mariae* (1 May 1946), Vatican English: [https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/en/encyclicals/documents/hf\\_p-xii\\_enc\\_01051946\\_deiparae-virginis-mariae.html](https://www.vatican.va/content/pius-xii/en/encyclicals/documents/hf_p-xii_enc_01051946_deiparae-virginis-mariae.html). Role: the consultation document itself (§§2, 4) and, in the page's own editorial note, its reserved circulation and later publication in AAS.

## Current teaching and framing

- \**Catechism of the Catholic Church*, English, Holy See web (IntraText) pages for §§484–511 and 963–975: [https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/\\_\\_\\_P1K.HTM](https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/___P1K.HTM), [https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/\\_\\_\\_P2C.HTM](https://www.vatican.va/archive/ENG0015/___P2C.HTM). Role: current catechetical framing; its apparatus supplied the checked DS loci (251, 427 chain, 503, 2803, 3903).
- \*Second Vatican Council, *Lumen gentium* (21 November 1964), ch. 8 (§§52–69), Vatican English web text: [https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist\\_councils/ii\\_vatican\\_council/documents/vat-ii\\_const\\_19641121\\_lumen-gentium\\_en.html](https://www.vatican.va/archive/hist_councils/ii_vatican_council/documents/vat-ii_const_19641121_lumen-gentium_en.html). Role: conciliar synthesis and cooperation-language control (LG 53, 54, 56–62, 63–65, 66–69).
- \*Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith, *Mater Populi Fidelis* (approved 7 October 2025; published 4 November 2025), Vatican English web text: [https://www.vatican.va/roman\\_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc\\_dff\\_doc\\_20251104\\_mater-populi-fidelis\\_en.html](https://www.vatican.va/roman_curia/congregations/cfaith/documents/rc_dff_doc_20251104_mater-populi-fidelis_en.html). Role: current controlling judgment on Co-redemptrix

(§22), mediation language (§27), and Mediatrix of All Graces (§§67–69); re-verified 2026-07-25 with a negative search for any later act.

- First Vatican Council, *Dei Filius* (1870), ch. 3 (DS 3011), English presentation at <https://www.papalencyclicals.net/councils/ecum20.htm> (translation identity not stated on the witness; paraphrased, not quoted). Role: criterion of dogma.

## Scripture

- Douay-Rheims Bible (Challoner revision; public domain), drbo.org: <https://drbo.org/chapter/49001.htm> (Lk 1), <https://drbo.org/chapter/01003.htm> (Gen 3, with its annotation on *ipsa conteret*), <https://drbo.org/chapter/50002.htm> (Jn 2, with its annotation at v. 4), <https://drbo.org/chapter/50019.htm> (Jn 19), <https://drbo.org/chapter/73012.htm> (Apoc 12). Role: English Scripture quotations.

## Patristic, scholastic, and medieval witnesses

- \*Ignatius of Antioch, *Epistle to the Ephesians* 7, 18–19, and Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* III.22.4 and V.19.1, in the Ante-Nicene Fathers (Roberts–Donaldson–Coxe; public domain), New Advent: <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0104.htm>, <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0103322.htm>, <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0103519.htm>. Role: second-century substance of the divine motherhood and the Eve–Mary parallel. The Ignatian page presents the shorter recension.
- Jerome, *The Perpetual Virginity of Blessed Mary* (against Helvidius, 383), NPNF 2/6 translation at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/3007.htm>. Role: the fourth-century arguments quoted in Chapter 4 (§§6, 12, 15–17, 19, 21–23), including the treatise’s own invective on marriage, reported and not endorsed.
- Vincent of Lérins, *Commonitory*, chs. XII, XV, XXIII, and Edgar C. S. Gibson’s introduction to John Cassian, both in NPNF series 2, vol. 11 (public domain), Christian Classics Ethereal Library: <https://ccel.org/ccel/sc/haff/npnf211>. Role: Latin reception of *Theotokos* (c. 434); the rule of development restated in 1854; and the reported occasion and date of Cassian’s seven books against Nestorius.
- Bernard of Clairvaux, letter to the canons of Lyons on the Conception of S. Mary (c. 1140; commonly cited as Ep. 174), in Samuel J. Eales, *Some Letters of Saint Bernard, Abbot of Clairvaux* (London: John Hodges, 1904; public domain), where it is numbered XLV: <https://ccel.org/ccel/bernard/letters>. Role: the classic medieval objection to the feast, with its closing submission to the See of Rome.
- Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, qq. 27 and 28 (Dominican Fathers translation, 1920; public domain), New Advent: <https://www.newadvent.org/summa/4027.htm>, <https://www.newadvent.org/summa/4028.htm>. Role: the Thomistic limit on the Immaculate Conception (q. 27, aa. 1–2), his report of the Roman practice on the feast (q. 27, a. 2 ad 3), and his four reasons against Helvidius (q. 28, a. 3); ST III, q. 35 cited at generality only.
- John Duns Scotus, *Ordinatio* III, d. 3, q. 1: standard scholarly reference for preservative redemption; no online witness checked, and no quotation made.

## Apocrypha, lists, and dating scholarship

- “Apocryphal Works on the Assumption of Mary” (the *Transitus* literature, including the account ascribed to John the Theologian), Ante-Nicene Fathers translation at <https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0832.htm>. Role: reception evidence only; no historical value claimed.
- *Decretum Gelasianum de libris recipiendis et non recipiendis*, part V, English translation of Ernst von Dobschütz’s edition (Texte und Untersuchungen 38.4, 1912) at [https://www.tertullian.org/decretum\\_eng.htm](https://www.tertullian.org/decretum_eng.htm). Role: the Roman list placing “the book which is called the Assumption of holy Mary” among the apocrypha. Date and authorship disputed; the Denzinger witness (DS 350–354) abbreviates the apocrypha list.
- Piotr Towarek, “Prayer ‘Sub Tuum praesidium’: Time of Origin, Place in Liturgy and Reception in Musical Culture. Outline of the Issues,” *Vox Patrum* 80 (2021), pp. 239–268, DOI 10.31743/vp.12929: <https://czasopisma.kul.pl/index.php/vp/article/view/12929> (abstract read). Role: the palaeographic dating dispute over P. Ryl. III 470.

- *Protevangelium of James*: cited as apocryphal reception evidence for the Epiphanian solution and for virginity in birth; no witness quoted.

## Documents of other communions (cited as their own acts)

- Patriarchal and Synodal Encyclical of Constantinople (Anthimus VII, 1895), art. XIII, English text at [http://orthodoxinfo.com/ecumenism/encyc\\_1895.aspx](http://orthodoxinfo.com/ecumenism/encyc_1895.aspx). Role: the Orthodox objection to the 1854 definition. Private site; translator and Greek edition unidentified; uncollated.
- *The Smalcald Articles* (Luther, 1537), Part I, art. IV, tr. F. Bente and W. H. T. Dau, *Triglot Concordia* (St. Louis: Concordia, 1921; public domain): <https://www.gutenberg.org/files/273/273-h/273-h.htm>. Role: the Lutheran confessional retention of the divine motherhood and perpetual virginity; the edition's bracket convention is noted at the point of use.
- Anglican–Roman Catholic International Commission, *Mary: Grace and Hope in Christ* (the Seattle Statement, agreed 2004, published 2005), §§9, 58–63, on the Holy See's Christian-unity site: <https://www.christianunity.va/content/unitacristiani/en/dialoghi/sezione-occidentale/comunione-anglicana/dialogo/arcic-ii/en.html>. Role: the most developed ecumenical treatment of the two modern dogmas, and the witness for the *Sub tuum praesidium* text quoted in Chapter 3. Status: an agreed statement of a bilateral dialogue commission, not an act of either communion's magisterium.

## C Generation Metadata

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**Model:** claude-fable-5; **unexposed:** reasoning-effort and sampling configuration

**Agent/runtime:** Anthropic Claude Code agent (research, drafting, typesetting, review); Claude Code CLI 2.1.219; **unexposed:** server revision

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